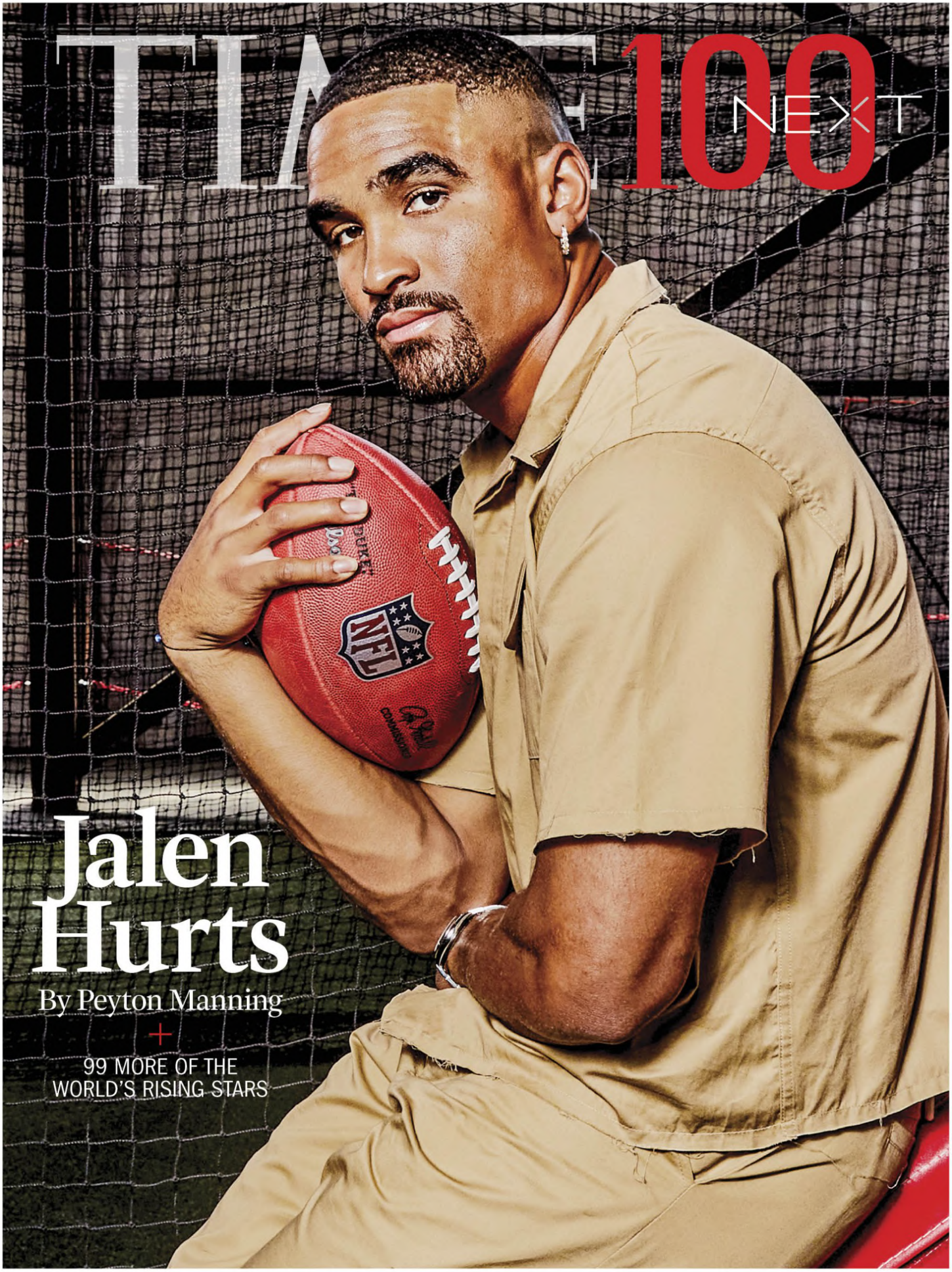
SEPT. 25, 2023

TIME 100 NEXT



Jalen Hurts

By Peyton Manning

+

99 MORE OF THE WORLD'S RISING STARS

TIME Magazine

[September 25th, 2023]

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Articles

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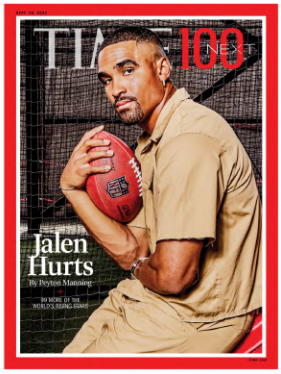
How We Chose the 2023 TIME100 Next

Sam Jacobs is Editor in Chief at TIME where he leads TIME's global newsroom and its journalism across all platforms. Since joining TIME in 2013, Jacobs has held a variety of senior editorial leadership positions. Previously, he was national political correspondent at Reuters, associate editor at Newsweek and staff reporter for The Daily Beast. His writing has appeared in the Boston Globe and New York Observer.



I first heard Wemimo Abbey speak in August at the inaugural TIME Impact House in Martha's Vineyard. It was clear to everyone that night that Abbey's is a story worth sharing. Together with Samir Goel, the two co-founders have built Esusu, a five-year-old company that helps Americans use their rental history to build credit scores. Abbey, who emigrated as a 17-year-old to the U.S. from Nigeria, watched his mother struggle to repay a high-interest loan because of a lack of credit history—something without which millions of people and communities across the country are unable to access loans that can create wealth.

Abbey's example is a powerful one, showing how personal insight can inspire societal change. It demonstrates that rethinking accepted ideas can create new possibilities for millions of people. His is one of 100 stories that are told within this year's TIME100 Next.

That is the point of the TIME100 Next. In 2019, we launched the list as part of our own effort to evolve how TIME tells stories. Traditionally, with efforts like Person of the Year and TIME100, we have used the power of our spotlight to draw attention to those who have achieved peak influence in their fields. But a great magazine and a great media company should not just reflect the present, it should push us forward, showing what is possible as well as what society's future and future leaders will look like. That is our ambition for TIME100 Next, our annual franchise recognizing the rising leaders in health, climate, business, sports, the arts and more.

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This year's list includes dozens of individuals, like Abbey and Goel, who are engineering new solutions to society's most pressing problems. They are scientists, CEOs, artists, an astronaut, and, naturally, a librarian too: Brooklyn Public Library's Nick Higgins, who is offering teens across the country access to books banned by their local libraries.

To recognize the TIME100 Next, we invite today's leaders to pay tribute to those who are following in their footsteps. For our three cover subjects this year: Peyton Manning, who first met Jalen Hurts when Hurts was a counselor at Manning's summer football program, praises the Philadelphia Eagles quarterback, who this summer signed a contract making him the highest paid football player in history, as "a model of how to approach a job"; Shania Twain embraces 30-year-old Kelsea Ballerini as "an old soul" who knows how to seize a big moment; and actor Omar Sy celebrates the French chef Mory Sacko's secret recipe—an ability to channel the crosscurrents of multiple cultures and "give up nothing of who he is."

Making a list like the TIME100 Next requires research and reporting from across TIME's global network of editors and correspondents. We sift through hundreds of suggestions and then meet each week to debate who belongs on the list. "Through this process, we get to know so many extraordinary leaders who are creating change across the world. Our hope is that this list offers a glimpse into their important work," says Cate Matthews, a TIME editorial director.

Putting together the TIME100 Next also requires the sensibility of organizing a great dinner party. Each selection impacts the next one, as we aim to include a growing variety of future headlinemakers, emphasize the storylines that fascinate us this year, and find individuals whose talents and achievements complement the group as a whole. Fortunately, in October, we will be getting the TIME100 Next together for an actual great dinner party, hosted in New York City, where the newest members of the TIME100 community will have a chance to toast one another's accomplishments and forge new connections, all in the spirit of inspiring new possibilities.

Correction, Sept. 14

The original version of this story misspelled, in one instance, Samir Goel's last name.

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Without Work Opportunities, Migrants in NYC Stuck in Overcrowded Temporary Housing

Sanya Mansoor is a reporter at TIME, where she has covered topics including state politics, criminal justice, voting access, religion, and South Asia.

Ali Sayyid, a father of six, tries to quickly change direction when his children hear the sound of an ice cream truck coming down a New York City street. He can't afford it.

"In Afghanistan, life was good and they were eating everything," says Sayyid, who asked that his name be changed so he does not lose his family's placement at the Roosevelt Hotel in midtown Manhattan.

Sayyid was a civil engineer in Afghanistan in 2021. But after the Taliban's takeover, he fled—first to Brazil and then across the Southern border into the U.S. He is among more than 100,000 migrants that have arrived in New York City over the last year. Many are desperate but unable to work legally—and trapped in the

city’s overcrowded temporary housing in the meantime. Nearly 60,000 remain in the city’s care, according to the mayor’s office.

More From TIME

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“Since the spring of 2022, our city has borne the brunt of a national crisis—providing shelter and care for a population greater than the entire city of Albany,” New York City Mayor Eric Adams said in an August 24 statement. New York City has a right-to-shelter law, which means officials cannot legally turn away anyone seeking shelter. The city and state have been fighting in court over the best way to house the influx of migrants. The city of New York sued 30 New York counties for issuing emergency executive orders meant to ban the city for arranging asylum seekers to stay in private hotels like the Roosevelt, which remains a designated arrival center in addition to functioning as a shelter. Last month, dozens of asylum seekers slept outside the Roosevelt Hotel hoping to secure a room like Sayyid and his family.

In response to traditional shelters reaching near-capacity in early June, the city created 206 emergency shelters, including respite centers in school gymnasiums and parking lots. These facilities

were originally intended to house migrants only for a few days, so they don't face the same kind of regulation that shelters do. Many are bare-bones spaces providing little more than a cot to sleep and a few meals.

Advocates have slammed the city for some of these facilities lacking access to showers and serving frozen meals to residents. "The respite centers are at the bottom of the barrel… By announcing the emergency situation they bypassed all the laws in the last 40 years that have been put in place," says Mammad Mahmoodi, co-founder of EV Loves NYC, a nonprofit focused on food insecurity in New York City. Rules around cots being spaced out and having an appropriate ratio of bathrooms per people can be overlooked, he says: "All of that went out of the window."

When asked about conditions at the respite centers, the mayor's office stressed that this is an emergency situation and noted that all sites now have viable shower options. A spokesperson with the office says the city considers respite centers to function as waiting rooms and not long-term stays. But many asylum seekers don't see a clear path to permanent housing.

As the migrant housing crisis grows in New York City, asylum-seekers, advocates, and New York politicians are increasingly focused on a related problem: the slow, kludgy process for getting federal work permits**.** Allowing for speedy work authorization so migrants can better support themselves, the thinking goes, could relieve some of the pressure on temporary housing. "We need the federal government to allow asylum seekers to work, so they can provide for themselves and their families," said Adams**.** Governor Kathy Hochul echoed his remarks in a public address last week—asking in particular to expedite work permits: "Let them work," she said. The Biden Administration hit back earlier this week, recommending that the city and state improve data collection at intake, communication around needing to apply for work

authorization and asylum, and ensuring case management and legal services are available at multiple shelter sites.

Sayyid and his family filed for asylum two weeks ago, but migrants need to wait 180 days after the application date before qualifying for a work permit. Work permit requests are taking about two months to process, according to a Department of Homeland Security (DHS) official. The agency notes that the 180-day waiting period is written into statute, so the agency does not have control over it—Congress does.

While some migrants resort to working cash jobs in construction or delivery, Sayyid says he won't consider that; if the police find out, it could tank his family's asylum case. "I will not put my family at risk," he says. In the meantime, money is tight. He says the city rejected his application for cash assistance two months ago and that it has only provided him with Medicaid and the shelter placement since he first arrived. "It's really time for the state and federal governments to take a more active role and to help people get work authorization," says Kathryn Kliff, a staff attorney with the Legal Aid Society. "Without work authorization, you might get exploited or not have a steady income… They don't feel like they have the protection to be able to work in a more above-ground job."

Sayyid is just one of thousands of migrants stuck in temporary housing without the ability to legally earn money towards a more permanent setup. Dozens of migrant men who crossed the Southern border to flee dire economic crises in Mauritania and Senegal ran to a street corner in Brooklyn on Sunday afternoon to get free food from a mutual aid group in the Clinton Hill and Fort Greene neighborhoods. They include former mechanics, electricians, and construction workers struggling to find jobs and currently living at one of the city's respite centers on Hall Street, near the Brooklyn Navy Yard. "It's a miracle that any of us are alive. It's impossible to live there. No one would risk their lives otherwise," Mohamad Sow, a man from Mauritania at the respite center, says in French. Sow asked for his name to be changed for fear that it could negatively affect his ability to stay in the U.S. (Members of the mutual aid group handing out food translated from French to English.)

The men are all worried about employment, as well as getting kicked out of their current dwelling because of a requirement for all single adult migrants to reapply for shelter every 60 days. Mayor Adams established the rule to provide more room for families with children, but these men don't know where they'll be able to stay next. Local bureaucracy has made it harder to get a city ID that would help migrants open bank accounts, access city services, and secure jobs—which would in turn help them get on the path to moving out of temporary housing. The migrants near Brooklyn Navy Yard say government forms ask for a residential address to get an IDNYC card, but the respite center won't let them use the address where it is located. Some have had to use addresses of churches or mosques instead. But just the city ID still isn't enough: The city notes that the IDNYC card can be used as proof of identity, but employers often require additional proof of work authorization. An official with the mayor's office said they would look into the issue.

Amid the increasingly dire situation, a loose web of nonprofits and aid groups has developed to help migrants with everything from basic necessities like bedding, socks, and hygiene kits, to legal advice, to food**.** EV Loves NYC, the food insecurity nonprofit, says it delivers about 2,000 meals on Sundays to shelters and respite centers across the city. At the Sixth Street Community Center—the group's home base—slabs of Hebrew text from when the building was a synagogue peek out behind murals of leftist leaders. "Hot chicken coming through," yells one volunteer, as another packs rice into boxes. On Aug. 22, there's an Indo-Chinese meal: coconut curry meatballs. A couple days later, the menu is fragrant rosemary chicken and stuffed grape leaves. There's always a vegan option. Sayyid, the Afghan father of six, relies on the group for halal chicken and meat meals.

Respite centers also often lack key supports like caseworkers. Caseworkers are at humanitarian relief or arrival centers but not at respite centers; they are also prioritizing families, according to an official with the mayor's office. Organizer Power Malu from the aid group Artists Athletes Activists sets up at a church in midtown Manhattan every Friday where he has helped gather volunteers to address the gaps. Among them are city employees helping in their free time, Legal Aid attorneys, and bilingual English teachers.

But the issues of work and housing persist. On a recent Friday afternoon, three other young men from Mauritania wait at the church to connect with a volunteer attorney to talk about legal pathways to work and live in the U.S. Elkhalil Mohamed Selma, 24, says he has been staying at a respite center for almost two months—one that was on the news for not having functioning showers. “The security talks with us like we are animals; says we are strangers in this country,” Selma says. Every day, he and the other two men go try and find work; every day, they come back without a job.

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Below is a rendering of the page up to the first error.

The Staggering Economic Impact of Taylor Swift's Eras Tour

Jeannie Kopstein is an associate video producer at TIME focused on breaking news.

Mariah Espada is a reporter at TIME. She covers internet culture, reality TV, and pop culture.

You don't have to be a Swiftie to have been touched in some way by Taylor Swift's Eras Tour, a stadium arena experience that kicked off in March. The tour, which pays homage to every era of the artist's illustrious 17-year career, is set to become the biggest tour of all time only a third of the way through its run.

If you live in one of the 20 locales Swift, 33, performed at in the last five months, your city has likely seen a boost in revenue from the hundreds of thousands of attendees who traveled from near and far. If you don't—or simply couldn't snag tickets due to the cost or the now infamous Ticketmaster snafu—chances are you've seen clips of the three-and-a-half hour show from celebrities' Instagram stories.

While there's much to say about the music, costumes, and production, the impact of the Eras Tour is starkly reflected in the numbers: a projected gross of $2.2 billion in North American ticket sales alone, and hundreds of millions of streams, reaching a nearly 80% spike in those listening to her music catalog in the weeks after the tour kicked off.

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After 53 shows, the first U.S. leg of the tour came to a close on Aug. 9. Swift originally announced 27 shows and has since extended the tour, adding new dates in cities like New Orleans, Indianapolis, and Toronto, which are all now anticipating a local economic boost. Eras is set to go international this month, starting with four shows in Mexico City, continuing its five-continent run through November 2024.

Swift's tour is in a league of its own, even among legendary groups like the Rolling Stones who have been touring for decades, other major touring artists like Harry Styles and Beyoncé and contemporaries like Adele with sold-out Las Vegas residencies, as the singer-songwriter brings her mega tour directly to her dedicated fans in various cities for multiple nights.

The reasons behind the Eras Tour's unmatched success are many. Nora Princiotti, staff writer at *The Ringer* and co-host of the podcast of *Every Single Album: Taylor Swift*, attributes part of the tour's success to the sheer depth and popularity of Swift's music

catalog. “I don’t know that anybody envisioned a tour of this scale ever happening. She can go three and a half hours and just hit after hit after hit,” says Princiotti.

There’s also the timing: The tour has become the perfect outing for concert-goers itching for a post-pandemic live music immersive experience. “We are in an experience economy where people crave going out and participating in social events,” says Alice Enders, a music industry analyst at Enders Analysis and a former senior economist at the World Trade Organization. “It’s no surprise that people are flocking to this Eras Tour experience in what is increasingly an otherwise digital environment we live in.”

And fans are acutely aware of Swift being connected to her body of work in a way that few artists are—she writes all her songs, has been protective of her music in the streaming boom, and is now releasing re-recordings of her discography to reclaim their master rights. It all adds up to a music industry enterprise the likes of which the world has never seen.

Read more: *Why You Can’t Remember That Taylor Swift Concert All Too Well*

The economic and cultural impact of the Eras Tour

Analysts estimate that the Eras Tour will likely surpass the $1 Billion mark next March, while Swift is touring internationally. If this projection holds true, she will achieve the milestone of the biggest tour in music history, surpassing Elton John’s multi-year farewell tour, which wrapped up earlier this summer and holds the current record of $939 million. The Eras Tour would then continue for another seven months before concluding in November of 2024 in Toronto—that is, unless rumors that Swift will release more dates come to fruition.

But the money goes far deeper than just net profits. The Eras Tour is projected to generate close to $5 billion in consumer spending in the United States alone. “If Taylor Swift were an economy, she’d be bigger than 50 countries,” said Dan Fleetwood, President of QuestionPro Research and Insights, in a story for GlobalNewsWire. On the opening night in Glendale, Ariz., the concert brought in more revenue for local businesses than Super Bowl LVII, which was held back in February in the same stadium. To use that event as a comparison, Swift has been performing the equivalent of two to three Super Bowls every weekend for the past five months (and six of seven nights at her last round of shows in Los Angeles).

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Typically, every $100 spent on live performances generates an estimated $300 in ancillary local spending on things like hotels, food and transportation. But for the Eras Tour, Swifties are taking this to the next level, dropping an estimated $1,300-$1,500 on things like outfits and costumes, merchandise, dining, and travel—boosting local economies by hundreds of millions of dollars in one weekend.

The Illinois governor credited the musician with reviving the state’s tourism industry after her three nights in Chicago. She was even mentioned in a report by the Fed, crediting her with fueling the national tourism industry.

The enthusiasm is so great that cities along her tour have experienced supply shortages. For one example: Swift mentions “friendship bracelets” in the song *You’re on Your Own, Kid*, off her most recent album *Midnights*. Swifties have taken this and run with it. Every concert is filled with tens of thousands of fans wearing and exchanging beaded bracelets spelling out the names of Swift songs and colloquialisms all the way up their arms. While this bracelet economy has brought new revenue to local businesses, businesses have also reported bead and sequin shortages.

This enthusiasm comes despite broader economic challenges. “There’s a cost of living crisis and people are still forking out thousands of dollars to see Taylor Swift,” says Enders. Despite this, a national study of concertgoers shows that even with an average of more than $1,300 spent per event, 91% said they would go again.

Not only is the Eras Tour an economic boon, but it has also become a cultural phenomenon. Every city Swift has visited over the course of the tour so far has pulled out all of the stops for her: Minneapolis was renamed “Swiftie-apolis;” Santa Clara, Calif., made her the honorary mayor; the New Jersey governor named the state sandwich of New Jersey after her. Now world leaders like the Chilean President, the mayor of Budapest, and Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau are asking her to bring the tour to their countries. The FBI tweeted out a Taylor Swift pun in July.

Princiotti says that in her role as a fan, it’s been both exciting and strange to see such a global embrace of Swift. “For as big as she has been for so long, even if this is a new peak, I think a lot of fans feel like they’ve spent their entire lives defending their love of her,” she says. “And there’s something very strange in seeing the U.S. government, or all of these various municipalities, just desperate to get a little sliver of the clout that comes from just being somewhat associated with Taylor Swift.”

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>
> — FBI Washington Field (@FBIWFO) July 10, 2023

Read more: ***Here’s Why Taylor Swift Is Re-Releasing Her Old Albums***

Beyond the concert tickets

Donning beaded bracelets and drawings of the figure “13” (Swift’s favorite number) on their hands, many Swifties attending her shows are just as eager to secure exclusive tour merchandise. Thousands of them line up for hours in advance to snag the coveted merch of $75 hoodies, $55 long-sleeve shirts and $45 T-shirts.

Fans are even clamoring to get their hands on physical copies of Swift’s music. “Streaming has taken over the purchase of the physical album product, but Taylor Swift is among the artists that still makes money from vinyl and CDs because they’ve become collector’s items for her fans,” says Enders.

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Swift creates different editions, reissues, and extras that make fans want to collect more and more copies of her albums in different forms. For her *Midnights* album, four of the five different album covers fit together to form a clock face, while another comes with bonus tracks, making buying different versions of the album a necessity for true fans. And some diehards admit they’ve purchased the vinyl versions without even owning a record player.

Midnights was the top-selling vinyl record in 2022, with 945,000 copies sold, making it the best-selling physical album since 1991. One out of every 25 vinyl records sold last year was a Taylor Swift album, and she is the first artist in history to simultaneously occupy at least seven of the top 10 spots on the Vinyl Albums chart. For her newest re-recorded album set to come out in October, *1989 (Taylor’s Version)*, Swift has already released multiple vinyl and special edition deluxe CDs for pre-order on her website, each with different cover art and unique additions.

View this post on Instagram

A post shared by Taylor Swift (@taylorswift)

The success of Swift's re-recording project

Swift's mega tour isn't the only thing she's dominated. Her streaming and chart success from her constant release of new and re-recorded music (six going on seven albums in the last three years) adds to the vast project that is Swift's domination of the global music industry.

"This moment for her is like an excellent HBO miniseries that's not just a primary narrative, but also a B plot and a C plot where the main narrative is the tour, but underneath that we have the album re-recordings," said Charlie Harding, music journalist and co-host of the podcast@SwitchedOnPop.

Swift's "Taylor's Version" re-recording project is an effort she started in 2019, when music mogul Scooter Braun bought record masters for her entire discography from her prior music label Big Machine Records. So far, Swift has released three re-recorded albums: *Fearless (Taylor's Version)*, *Red (Taylor's Version)*, and *Speak Now (Taylor's Version)*, with the re-recorded editions all including additional "vault songs" that didn't make it to the final versions of their original albums.

Read more: *Why Music Manager Scooter Braun Is at the Center of a Media Storm*

Fans have embraced Swift's attempt to claim her music back, opting to stream the re-recordings more than the original versions, thus dethroning the catalog once owned by Braun. (He sold the rights to Shamrock Holdings in November 2020.)

Swift's project has broken several music records in the wake of the album re-releases. Her latest re-recorded album, *Speak Now (Taylor's Version)*, a recording of her 2010 studio album, made history when it went straight to the top of the charts as her 12th no. 1—making her the woman with the most no. 1 albums and the first person with five albums simultaneously on Spotify's Top Ten Albums Global chart.

And Swift's *Eras* tour is directly linked to the success of her streaming. "The live music performance is actually a driver to the streaming platforms," says Enders. "When you go to see an Eras show you're rediscovering Taylor Swift and you go back to listen to her music when you get home and in the days after."

So far, Swift is halfway through her re-recording project, with three albums still to come. Swift announced on Aug. 9, when closing out her six-show residency at Los Angeles' So-Fi Stadium, that her next re-recorded album will be her synth pop *1989* album, due Oct. 27.

> Surprise!! 1989 (Taylor's Version) is on its way to you ➡️SOON!
> The 1989 album changed my life in countless ways, and it fills me with such excitement to announce that my version of it will be out October 27th. To be perfectly honest, this is my most FAVORITE re-record I've ever done…
> pic.twitter.com/JFYOWhBxhj
>
> — Taylor Swift (@taylorswift13) August 10, 2023

"It's kind of like the Marvel Cinematic Universe," says Harding, using another onscreen metaphor. "We're in the Taylor Swift cinematic universe at any given moment. There's endless amounts of discussion to be had at every level of this world that she's created, and each one I think serves a different audience."

With more tour stops on the horizon and three more albums to re-release, Swift isn't slowing down any time soon. The music sensation has even exceeded her own expectations. On the last night of the first U.S. leg of the tour, Swift told the crowd, "I figured it would be fun, but I did not know it would be like this."

Harding says it's not just a recipe for financial success, but for spectacular longevity. "Taylor Swift has the capacity to be around for a whole lifetime," he says. "I think the big question I have is: where do you go from here?"

Correction, Aug. 24

The original version of this story stated that Scooter Braun still owns the master rights to Swift's first six albums. Braun sold the rights to Shamrock Holdings in November 2020.

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The ‘Hurricane Tax’ Hitting Florida Alongside Idalia

Alejandro de la Garza is a staff writer at TIME. He covers climate technology from EVs to geoengineering.

In Florida, it won’t just be those with homes and businesses hit directly by Hurricane Idalia who might be stuck picking up the pieces. Thanks to a broken home insurance market, a particularly bad hurricane could spread financial fallout throughout the state, leaving residents from Pensacola to Key West stuck paying repair bills for years.

Beset by hurricanes made more severe and more frequent by climate change, as well as rampant fraud and tides of frivolous lawsuits, dozens of insurers in the state have closed up shop or stopped selling new home insurance policies in the state in recent years. (Farmers became the most recent big insurer to pull out of the state last month). Residents have increasingly turned to Citizens Property Insurance Corporation, a public entity established by the Florida government as the state’s so-called “insurer of last resort” for people unable to find affordable rates from private insurers. For

more and more residents, though, Citizens is becoming the first and only option, especially for those with coastal homes at particular risk from hurricanes. In 2019, Citizens had about 400,000 home insurance policies on its books; today, it has more than 1.3 million, about twice as many as the state's next-largest insurer.

With so many homeowners using Citizens policies, each hurricane season becomes a roll of the dice for almost every Floridians' pocketbook. When a normal insurance company takes big losses, it goes bankrupt. But if hurricane winds destroy too many homes covered by Citizens policies and the insurer faces bigger bills than it can afford to pay, the public company won't go belly up. Instead, such an event can trigger what is known as an assessment, wherein state law mandates that Citizens imposes fees on private insurance policies across the state in order to cover its payouts. And it's not just property insurance-policy holders that may have to pull out the checkbook. If you live in Florida and have auto insurance, but can't afford to own a home, you can still be stuck contributing to funds that pay for homeowners to rebuild after a big storm. "We have one of the highest populations of fixed-income senior citizens in the country," says Mark Friedlander, a spokesperson for the Insurance Information Institute, a trade group. "We have many low-income households that are literally living paycheck to paycheck. They can't afford this."

[video id=5U8lepHq autostart="viewable"]

That situation last occurred after the 2004-05 hurricane season, when 10 hurricanes left Florida residents paying off Citizens' $1.7 billion tab though 2015. Currently, the insurer has about $4.8 billion in the bank, and there's a chance that Idalia could break that budget, though that's less likely now that the brunt of the storm has missed Florida's most populated areas like Tampa. But there are still many months left in the Atlantic hurricane season, and a lot of warm water offshore that can serve as fuel for powerful storms. "We probably only need one or two more [hurricanes] to make

landfall [this season] before Citizens has to do an assessment," says Charles Nyce, a professor of risk management and insurance at Florida State University. "When you have 1.3 million policyholders, that $4.8 billion is going to go very quickly."

There's no easy solution. Laws passed in the Florida legislature last year have cut down on some of the fraud and excessive legal filings that had been choking the state's private insurers, and Citizens is trying to offload some of its bloated policy roster to the private market.

But other forces are still pushing in the wrong direction. One reason Citizens is flooded with policies is because it's legally barred from raising rates fast enough to stay in line with the private market. Private insurance rates in Florida have climbed sharply in recent years; Citizens rates are generally about 40% lower, according to the Insurance Information Institute, and the state government recently rejected a request from Citizens' management to impose a 12.1% rate hike. That could keep prices lower for policyholders, but ultimately cost more residents in the longer term. As Freidlander puts it: "It's a recipe for a hurricane tax that would be applied to all Florida consumers."

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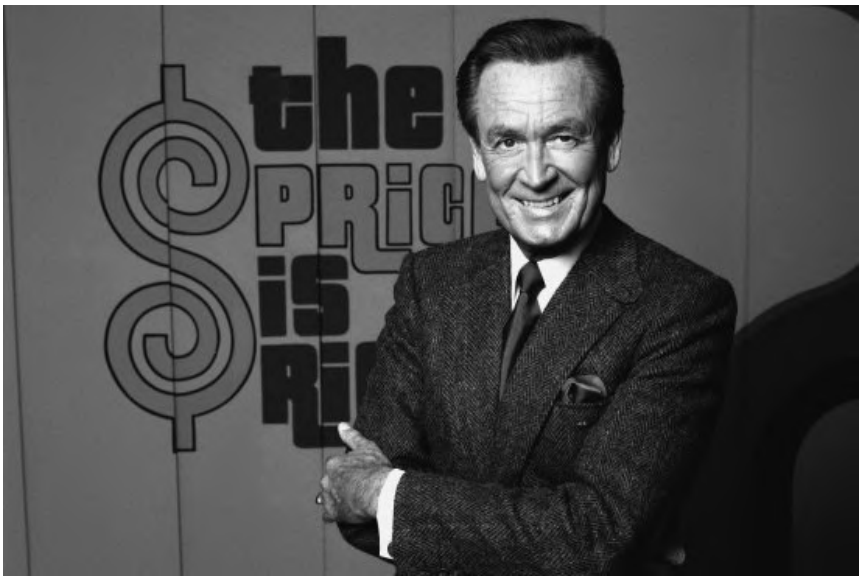
Bob Barker, Iconic Host of The Price Is Right, Dies

Mahita Gajanan is an editor at TIME. She covers culture.



Bob Barker, the affable television icon and animal rights activist who hosted *The Price Is Right* for more than three decades, died Saturday. He was 99.

A fixture on American TV screens for decades, Barker was host of the iconic CBS game show from 1972 to 2007—memorably reminding viewers at the end of each episode to get their pets spayed or neutered. The program has become the longest-running game show in North America.

Barker came to *The Price is Right* in 1972, slightly before his stint as the host of the game show *Truth or Consequences* ended. The show was a modern reboot of an earlier version of *The Price Is Right*, which previously ended in 1965. Well-suited to the daytime game show, Barker eventually became synonymous with the program and a fixture of pop culture.

As *The Price Is Right* host, Barker became the subject of stories that gained national relevance. In 1987, he famously had to get permission from top producers to stop dyeing his hair. Ultimately, Barker's natural grey/white hair color made him even more popular. "I went on vacation and I just let it go," he told the Los Angeles *Times* in 1990. "When I came home the people on the show said, 'You look better this way than you do with it dyed or tinted. Why don't you just leave it this way?'"

Despite his wholesome public image, Barker was also at the center of a few controversies during his 35 years on *The Price Is Right*. Multiple women filed lawsuits against Barker; the show's production company was also sued on several occasions, not all during Barker's tenure, by models and staff members. One of the most high-profile lawsuits against Barker came in 1994 from the model Dian Parkinson, who alleged that Barker forced her to have sex with him so she could keep her job as one of "Barker's Beauties"—a term used to describe the models who showcased the prizes on *The Price Is Righ*t. She also claimed that she was later wrongfully terminated. Barker, who became a widower in 1981, at first denied her claim but later said he and Parkinson had a consensual sexual relationship for years. Parkinson later dropped the lawsuit.

Barker will also be remembered for his fervent love of animals, which he intertwined with *The Price Is Right*. He became famous for ending each show with a message to the audience, "Help control the pet population. Have your pets spayed or neutered." Offscreen, he was an ardent animal rights activist who spoke out against animal abuse, appearing in several campaigns for People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals (PETA) and supporting organizations like the United Activists for Animal Rights. In 1988, he quit as host of the Miss Universe and Miss USA pageants after more than 20 years over the show's use of fur coats. In 1995,

Barker established the DJ&T Foundation, which helps to fund spay and neuter clinics in an effort to curb animal overpopulation.

Barker developed the genial persona he was known for in a broadcasting career that began in radio. Born in Darrington, Wash., he grew up in Mission, S.D., spending his early childhood on the Rosebud Indian Reservation. In his 2009 autobiography, *Priceless Memories*, Barker wrote that he was part Sioux.

After his father died in 1930, his mother remarried and moved the family to Springfield, Mo., where Barker went to high school. Barker later entered Drury University on a basketball scholarship, but left after World War II broke out. He joined the U.S. Navy to become a fighter pilot. However, he never saw combat because the war ended before he could be assigned to a seagoing squadron.

Barker married his high school sweetheart, Dorothy Jo Gideon, in 1945, and went back to college after the war. As he told the Television Academy in a lengthy interview about his life, Barker applied for a job at a local Missouri radio station after hearing that the manager there had an affinity for airplanes. Barker hoped that his training as a fighter pilot would pique the manager's interest. It worked; his first job in radio involved writing local news and announcing sportscasts for KTTS-FM radio in Springfield.

Later, he worked in radio at stations in Florida before eventually landing in California, where he hosted his own program, *The Bob Barker Show*, from 1950 to 1956.

Television came into Barker's life in the late 1950s, when he became host of his first game show, *Truth or Consequences*, which had aired on NBC since 1940. As the title indicates, contestants had to answer questions correctly or pay "consequences"—which usually involved elaborate stunts. Barker hosted the show until 1974, even as it coincided with the dawn of *The Price Is Right*. He became known for his sign-off on the show: "Bob Barker saying goodbye, and hoping all your consequences are happy ones."

But it was Barker's time as *The Price Is Right* host that made him an American cultural figure—which resulted in a famous cameo in the Adam Sandler comedy *Happy Gilmore*.

Following his retirement from *The Price Is Right* in 2007, Barker focused on his animal rights activism and still made some surprise appearances on TV. In 2015, he returned to *The Price Is Right* as an April Fool's joke, thrilling audiences.

"I'm here because I was selected by *The Price is Right* to be their April fool," Barker said at the time. "I know the world is full of fools, but I am a carefully selected fool, and it is a pleasure to be with you."

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Trump Booked at Atlanta Jail After Surrendering on Election Charges

Brian Bennett is the senior White House correspondent at TIME, based in the Washington, D.C. bureau. He has covered wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, interviewed world leaders, traveled across the globe with President Trump and President Biden, and written extensively about intelligence, immigration and the fallout of major disasters.

Nik Popli is a reporter at TIME, based in the Washington, D.C. bureau. He covers economic policy and national politics, focusing on Congress, technology, and the economy.

Donald Trump has now seen the inside of a jail.

The former President surrendered to authorities at the Fulton County Jail in Atlanta on Thursday to face charges that he illegally schemed to overturn his 2020 election loss in the state.

It’s the fourth time in six months Trump has surrendered himself to face criminal charges. In March, he was charged with falsifying business records to hide a hush money payment during his 2016

campaign. In June, he was charged with refusing to return classified documents. In early August, he was slapped with charges for his actions to try to overturn the 2020 election results.

The case against him in Georgia is the first time authorities are requiring Trump to be booked inside a jail and stand for a mug shot. Trump's previous appearances were in courthouses where judges agreed to waive his need to be weighed and have his picture taken. In Atlanta, Trump agreed to pay the required $200,000 bond and other conditions of his release, including pledging to not intimidate any witnesses or co-defendants online.

The Fulton County booking system recorded Trump as having "blond or strawberry" hair, blue eyes, a height of 6'3" and weight of 215 pounds. The mug shot had not been released as of Thursday evening.

Trump has repeatedly promoted his multiple criminal indictments in fundraising pleas for his 2024 presidential campaign, raising millions of dollars off being caught in the grinding wheels of the American judicial system. Trump has painted the charges as an orchestrated effort by Democrats to stop him from winning back the White House, claiming that he's being persecuted in a broader effort to silence his supporters.

It's a political talking point that's so far resonated with Republican primary voters. Despite the serious felony allegations against him, Trump leads the Republican primary race by a wide margin. A Yahoo News/YouGov poll from mid-August showed that 52% of registered Republicans preferred Trump as their candidate, giving him a 40-point lead over the runner up in the polling, Florida Governor Ron DeSantis.

The case against Trump in Georgia

Fani Willis, the Fulton County District Attorney, began investigating Trump in early 2021 after a recording was released of the former President asking Georgia's Republican Secretary of State Brad Raffensperger to "find" 11,780 votes—one more than the margin of his loss in the decisive swing state. Raffensperger refused, claiming that Georgia officials had already counted the vote three times, won multiple lawsuits over the outcome and debunked extravagant fraud claims by Trump's team. Trump has maintained he did nothing wrong in contacting the state officials, describing the phone call as "absolutely perfect."

The Fulton County investigation soon expanded to other alleged efforts by Trump and his allies, including the breach of voting data in Georgia's rural Coffee County, the targeted abuse and harassment of state election workers, and the orchestrated attempt to send slates of alternate electors to Congress to undermine the will of voters.

Trump was charged with 13 counts in the case, including violating state racketeering laws and soliciting a public official to violate his oath of office, conspiring to commit forgery in the first degree, conspiring to file false documents, and making false statements.

More than a dozen of Trump's associates were also charged under Georgia's anti-racketeering law for conspiring to nullify the election, including Rudy Giuliani, the former New York mayor who was Trump's personal attorney at the time; former White House Chief of Staff Mark Meadows; attorneys John Eastman and Kenneth Cheseboro, both of whom devised a scheme to send alternate Trump electors to the Electoral College; and other lawyers in Trump's orbit who pushed wild or legally dubious theories for how to reverse the election outcome, such as Sidney Powell and Jenna Ellis. A handful of Georgia-based Trump attorneys and advisers were also included in the indictment.

Speaking to reporters at the Atlanta airport after being booked, Trump said that he did “nothing wrong” and called the case a “travesty of justice.” He added: “We have every right to challenge an election we think is dishonest.”

Here’s what’s next

With his latest legal challenge, Trump is now facing the prospect of being put on trial at least seven times in the next year, clogging up his campaign calendar with multiple court appearances that intersect with key events on the 2024 political schedule. Prosecutors in the case have proposed that the trial start on October 23, 2023, which is the same month he will stand trial in a civil fraud suit. Trump’s lawyers have asked for a 2026 trial.

Of all the prosecutions targeting Trump, the case against him in Georgia could carry the most risk for the former President. Unlike the other four criminal cases, Trump cannot escape the charges with a payoff or self-pardon if he returns to the White House.

Trump’s rivals in the 2024 presidential race have been wary of directly attacking the former President, who remains the undisputed frontrunner in the crowded field. All but two of Trump’s rivals said at the first Republican debate on Wednesday night they would support his campaign if he wins the nomination—even if he’s convicted in any of the cases before the election.

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Who I'm Hurting By Shopping At Walmart

Alana Semuels is an economic correspondent at TIME. She covers work, consumer spending, retail, gender, and technology. She is a four-time nominee for the Gerald Loeb Award for Distinguished Business and Financial Journalism, and has won awards from the Society of Business Editors and Writers and the Los Angeles Press Club.

Every week, I go onto Walmart's website and order a bunch of groceries to be delivered to my house and then feel a little bit guilty.

Walmart is a multi-billion dollar corporation with headquarters more than 1,000 miles from my home; the money I spend there goes to shareholders and executives who live far away, instead of to my local grocery store, Key Food, an 86-year-old co-op of independently owned stores based near my home in New York. By shopping at Walmart, I am likely contributing to the demise of the independently-owned grocery store, which is disappearing across the country.

But the prices make the choice easy. On a recent day, the 42-oz tub of Quaker Oats I get each week was $9.99 at Key Foods and $5.68 at Walmart; a 500 ml bottle of California Olive Ranch olive oil was $14.49 at Key Foods and $8.37 at Walmart; Rao's homemade tomato sauce was $9.99, while I could have gotten the exact same item on Walmart for $6.88. On these three items alone, I saved $14 by shopping at Walmart.

These prices are one reason that Walmart captures one in four grocery dollars in America, but there's an argument to be made that Walmart and other big chains including Dollar General, which is expanding at a rapid clip across the country, come by those prices unfairly because of their market power.

There's a law on the books—1936's Robinson-Patman Act—that essentially says suppliers in any industry can't give lower prices and special deals to big chain stores if it costs the same to serve them as other stores. The law also says retailers can't try and bully suppliers into giving those discounts.

But because Walmart and dollar stores are so huge, representing a big part of a supplier's business, they're able to extract deals and low prices from suppliers, according to Small Business Rising and the Main Street Competition Coalition, two groups of independent business owners making their case in Congressional hearings and television ads. The pandemic highlighted just how unfairly Walmart can wield its power, the small businesses are telling regulators, because it was able to demand that suppliers stock its shelves when competitors weren't able to get the same products for weeks or months. It's not just groceries; independent pharmacies, book stores, auto parts stores, and other types of retailers are also struggling on an uneven playing field, they say.

Read More: *I Tried to Live Off Women-Owned Businesses. Turns Out, Men Still Run Everything*

Walmart's leverage may seem like a good deal for consumers like me. In an era of runaway inflation, who doesn't want the lowest prices they can get? But during the pandemic, it meant consumers living in lower-income areas far from big box stores weren't able to get the groceries they needed. And the rise of Walmart contributes to the demise of those independent stores, the grocers say. Since suppliers lose money by giving such low prices to stores like Walmart, they increase the prices they charge to other stores, a phenomenon economists have called the "waterbed effect." The higher-priced stores struggle, lose customers and go out of business. Then the big box stores, their dominance established and their competitors wiped out, raise prices, the grocers say.

"Walmart's consolidation of the grocery market has led to people paying higher prices across the board," says Stacy Mitchell, co-executive director of the Institute for Local Self-Reliance (ILSR), an advocacy group challenging consolidation of corporations. At Walmart, for instance, an NPR investigation found that Walmart prices went up around 23% between August 2019 and December 2022; some of the steepest hikes included Quaker Old-Fashioned Oats, which climbed 73% between August 2019 and December 2022; and Bounty paper towels, which increased 67%, says Mitchell. Consolidation in the economy has increased prices across many industries, according to a recent paper from the Federal Reserve Bank of Boston. ILSR also points to the success of Dollar General, Dollar Tree, and Family Dollar stores in spreading across America, pushing independent grocers out of business, as another reason there's an uneven playing field. They say the dominance of huge chain stores is proof the Robinson-Patman Act needs to be enforced.

Walmart did not respond to multiple requests for comment. FMI, the Food Industry Association, which represents Walmart, Target, and many other grocers, declined to comment. Neither Dollar

General nor Dollar Tree, which also owns Family Dollar, returned a request for comment.

The argument that big chains need to be reined in has gained traction with the Federal Trade Commission, which is tasked with enforcing the Robinson-Patman Act. Under Chair Lina Khan, appointed in 2021, the FTC has embarked on an aggressive path of antitrust enforcement, and in March, Khan said that the agency wanted to bring more cases under the law "in short order." (Khan wrote an influential critique of how antitrust policy failed to rein in Amazon while a student at Columbia Law School.) In addition, FTC Commissioner Alvaro Bedoya has embarked on a listening tour around the country, meeting with independent grocery stores and pharmacy operators and talking about how Robinson-Patman enforcement could help them thrive. The FTC has reportedly opened a preliminary investigation recently into whether pricing practices at Coca-Cola and PepsiCo violated Robinson-Patman, but has not yet brought a formal action.

"The law may be broken—grocery stores like yours, in the way I read the law, should be able to access the same deals as your competitors," Bedoya told a room of people in July as he visited Oasis, an independent grocery store that opened in 2021 in North Tulsa, Okla., after the city passed an ordinance limiting the proliferation of dollar stores. "One of the big things that means is no secret discounts, no secret deals for one company versus another."

Bedoya visited Oasis, which has thrived in a predominantly Black neighborhood, and Buche's, an independent grocery store in Pine Ridge, S.D., in part because he hopes that enforcement of the law will allow more stores like them to proliferate.

"I do think that the corporate power in this country is such that slowly, folks—no matter what their politics are—are starting to say this is too much," he said, to the people gathered, who included

local politicians, residents, and people from other communities hoping to open independent grocery stores. “My hope is that five or 10 or 15 years from now, there will be bipartisan agreement that we need to work harder to protect small businesses like Oasis.”

A bipartisan group of 43 members of Congress, including representatives Hakeem Jeffries (D-N.Y.) and W. Gregory Steube (R-Fla.) wrote a letter to the FTC in March of 2022 asking it to bring more actions against companies that have violated Robinson-Patman. “The anticompetitive effects of discriminatory pricing and product supply directed to certain businesses (sometimes but not always small and medium-sized businesses) ripple through the entire supply chain—harming consumers as well as independent producers,” they wrote in the letter.

Why the Government May Go After Walmart

That government officials are standing up for independent businesses represents a sea change in how we think about what’s good and bad for the American shopper. For decades, the FTC and Justice Department have focused antitrust enforcement on protecting consumers from monopolies that can drive up prices, and concluding that if a shopper is getting a good deal and prices are low, there’s no reason for the government to step in. Enforcing Robinson-Patman would mean the government will focus less on whether I’m getting a good deal on groceries and more on whether the fabric of my community—and others that look very different from it—are better off with the status quo.

The biggest grocery stores and box stores aren’t evenly distributed around the country—they tend to be clumped in more affluent, suburban areas, Bedoya said, in an interview with TIME. Rural and urban areas are disproportionately served by independent grocers, and as dollar stores and big box stores come in and undercut those grocers on price, they go out of business. A Walmart located in the

suburbs, even if it's just eight or nine miles away from a center city, is not a good solution for neighborhoods where people don't have cars or access to consistent public transit.

"What you're left with is some of the poorest people in the country, some of the people in the most underserved areas, are left without a place to buy fresh groceries or just groceries, period," Bedoya says.

For decades, small businesses in America have failed as lower-priced big box stores spread. Many Americans have, by and large, concluded—with views bolstered by pop culture hits like the movie *You've Got Mail*—that small stores can't compete in a free market where big boxes can win on efficiency. But the FTC is challenging the long-held assumption that the death of independently-owned stores is inevitable in an age of Walmart and Amazon.

"That was unequivocally the heart of Robinson-Patman," says Bedoya. "That $1 spent at the local store becomes $30 within the community and that this is good for our community in a way that the chains are not." The Robinson-Patman Act was passed in 1936 in response to the supermarket giant A&P, which was spreading across the country and putting local grocers out of business. Congress decided that Robinson-Patman could help the independent grocers compete with A&P, which seemed important during the Great Depression when stores were going out of business left and right. A&P didn't offer credit, like the local grocer did, and it didn't deliver groceries, two reasons why Congress supported Robinson-Patman, says Bedoya.

For a long time, from when it was passed until the late 1960s, Robinson-Patman was “a prime enforcement priority” of the FTC, John Kirkwood, an antitrust expert and professor of law at Seattle University School of Law. But the field of antitrust underwent a populist revolution starting in the late 1960s and 1970s, in which academics, lawyers, and eventually judges, decided it was more important to prioritize consumer welfare than small businesses. A 1969 report by Ralph Nader excoriated the Federal Trade Commission for protecting small businesses, arguing that doing so drove up prices for consumers.

In the wake of the Nader report and the populist push to prioritize consumer welfare over all else, the FTC and Justice Department slowed the pace of bringing cases under Robinson-Patman. Those that they did bring were less and less successful, until it became extremely difficult to bring a Robinson-Patman case and win, says Kirkwood, who was the lead counsel on one of the last Robinson-Patman cases brought by the FTC, filed in 1988.

The Problem With Walmart’s Low Prices

On one hand, it makes sense Walmart would get lower prices from the cereal company or the juice seller. It’s ordering huge amounts of product and that sheer volume creates efficiencies that arguably

save suppliers money. But the grocers are arguing that Walmart and big boxes aren't actually creating efficiencies—while still using their size to extract deals.

The law allows for suppliers to give retailers a better price if it saves them money to do so, says Bedoya. "If it's actually cheaper to make and sell someone 1,000 widgets because of some efficiency that you earn at the factory, fine, pass it along, no problem," he says. "But when it's the purchaser of 1,000 widgets saying, 'Hey, I'm big and powerful and you're gonna give me this deal no matter what,' for almost 100 years, the federal government has responded with 'you can't do that.'"

Many independent grocers have banded together into cooperatives so they'll have more bargaining power. Those giant co-ops buy billions of dollars of groceries and have warehouses all around the country, just like Walmart does. Associated Wholesale Grocers, for instance, is a food co-op that serves 3,400 member supermarkets, representing $24 billion in sales. By contrast, there are 4,631 Walmarts in the U.S. AWG buys goods by the truckload, rather than the case, so a supplier sends a truck to its warehouse in the same way it would send a truck to Walmart, says David Smith, the president and chief executive officer of Associated Wholesale Grocers (AWG).

When Robinson-Patman was enforced in the 1970s, says Smith, who grew up in the grocery business, suppliers would issue rate cards to tell grocery stores how much an item cost, depending on how much the stores bought. A case, a pallet, and a full truckload of a product would all have different rates. But in the last three decades, he says, as Walmart has grown and gained market power, "there's no transparency whatsoever. And what's happening is efficiency is being surpassed by leverage."

As Walmart has grown over the last three decades, it has gained leverage because of its huge market share—25% of all groceries

purchased, compared to around 10% at competitors like Kroger and Costco. According to AWG, its stores average about 35,000 square feet, compared to 110,000 of a typical Walmart, says Jason Goldberg, chief commerce strategy office at Publicis Group —and so they buy far less product overall.

Suppliers haven't issued list prices to retailers in decades, Goldberg says; instead, they sit down with retailers and negotiate prices alongside joint marketing spending and product placement. Deals are very hard to compare because they have so many moving parts, but one thing is for sure: "The retailers with the least leverage are going to pay the most," he says, "and the biggest retailers with the most leverage are going to pay the least."

The grocers say that the discounts Walmart gets are not commensurate with the efficiencies the company creates. Many store owners have experiences like that of R.F. Buche, who owns 23 independent grocery, convenience, and hardware stores in South Dakota, including the store that Bedoya visited in Pine Ridge. He will sometimes walk into a Walmart and see lower prices on the shelves than he can get wholesale through AWG. In December, for instance, he saw Walmart selling a dozen eggs for $2.27 when he was buying them for $3; Walmart was selling iceberg lettuce for $1.88 a head when he was getting it for $4.46.

"My customers just don't understand when they look at my shelf price and Walmart's shelf price," says Buche, who has had to sell three stores since 2019 because it was impossible to keep them afloat.

Read More: *Maybe Americans Don't Mind High Prices Anymore*

Suppliers' allegiance to Walmart worsened during the pandemic, say Buche and other grocers. Because Walmart makes up such a big share of a supplier's business, they could demand on-time delivery even during the pandemic, when everything was running

late. In September 2020, Walmart told suppliers they needed to be making on-time and in-full shipments 98% of the time or face steep fines; as a result, suppliers shifted whatever they had available to Walmart. Buche and independent grocers, on the other hand, couldn't get the items their customers needed, and so their customers switched over to the box stores. It's perfectly legal for Walmart to enforce those terms; independents could try enforcing them too, but would likely have a harder time doing so because they represent a much smaller share of a suppliers' business.

Suppliers mince no words explaining how dependent they are on Walmart; in regulatory filings, giants like Kraft Heinz and Nestle mention Walmart by name, explaining that consolidation in grocery has led to customers with increased purchasing power, and that those customers can demand lower pricing, more favorable terms, and more promotional programs.

Buche says he's still "on allocation" from hundreds of manufacturers, meaning he can only get a certain amount of certain products, while he sees no evidence of such shortages at Walmart. Sometimes, stores like Dollar General and Walmart will stock products that he isn't even offered—different sizes or configurations. That's what is unfair, grocers say—that there appears to be a whole different market for the big guys that's invisible to everyone else.

“If we’re willing to purchase the same quantities of product as the competition, we should be afforded the same price,” says Chris Jones, senior vice president of government relations at the National Grocers Association, a trade group representing independent grocers. “But those conversations don’t even happen.”

Advocates for business, however, say enforcement of Robinson-Patman would result in higher prices for consumers. By enforcing the law, said former FTC Commissioner Joshua Wright at a Cato Institute event in 2022, the government would not be prioritizing consumer welfare, but would be instead just assuming that “big is bad.”

Who Gets Hurt When Independent Stores Go Out of Business

If you live near a box store—and 90% of Americans live within 10 miles of a Walmart—it may not seem important that there are fewer independent grocery stores, or that prices are going up at those places.

Indeed, some analysts make the argument that small stores aren’t really that necessary, especially in the world of e-commerce. Walmart delivers to my house, after all—can’t it also deliver to food deserts?

“There’s simply no legitimate argument that somehow the U.S. will be worse off if smaller groceries go out of business—as long as there is a replacement for consumers to buy groceries,” says Britain Ladd, a logistics analyst who has tracked the disappearance of small grocery stores. Even if Robinson-Pattman were enforced and prices from suppliers were more even, he argues, many independent grocery stores would fail anyway. They can’t invest in the automation or technology that the giants can, and have a harder time keeping costs down.

But communities that have lost independent grocery stores say their residents don't have any other options. "Everyone deserves access to healthy foods and eating options," says Latisha Brunson, a council woman in Pine Bluff, Ark., where a grocery store closed in November 2022, leaving her ward the only one in the city without one. Her ward does have dollar stores with shelf-stable products, but now residents can't shop for fresh food without a car.

Read More: *The Fight Over Non-Competes Is Heating Up. The FTC Must Stand Strong*

In theory, Robinson-Patman should have helped keep Pine Bluff's independent grocer's open. But it's going to be "a heavy lift" for the FTC to successfully start enforcing the law again, says Kirkwood, the Seattle University professor.

If the FTC does file cases under Robinson-Patman, they will eventually end up in appeals courts and maybe even the Supreme Court, and both are likely to take a dim view of it because they are so conservative, he says. "You'd have to go up against these judges [who think] it's the left-wing FTC trying to revive the Robinson-Patman Act when sensible business types think it is a bad idea," he says. Prosecuting a Robinson-Patman violation might work if the government can prove that consumers, not just small businesses, were the victims of this price bullying, says Kirkwood.

This seems to be the FTC's tack, and could be why Commissioner Bedoya is visiting communities like North Tulsa and Pine Ridge, where dollar stores and big boxes have made it hard for independent groceries to compete and for consumers to get the groceries they need.

However, there's a big question for consumers here: whether the FTC's enforcement actions could drive prices up. I like the idea of shopping at Key Foods, after all, but my pocketbook vastly prefers the cheap prices at Walmart. I should, I suppose, be willing to pay a

little more so that Americans living far from a big box store can also get fresh groceries, but few people are going to volunteer to pay higher prices on behalf of an unknown fellow citizen.

Economists are still divided on whether Robinson-Patman enforcement truly raises prices; there are studies that show it does, and studies that show it doesn't. If the FTC can somehow prove that enforcement won't raise prices, that it will instead create a country with big chain stores and small independents with similar prices, it may have a fighting chance at restarting enforcement after more than 30 years. But it's going to be an uphill battle.

And if people like me keep shopping at Walmart while they fight that battle, giving Walmart even more leverage, it could get even harder.

Correction, Aug. 23

The original version of this story misstated the size of stores participating in the Associated Wholesale Grocers (AWG) coop. They average 35,000 square feet, not 6,000 square feet.

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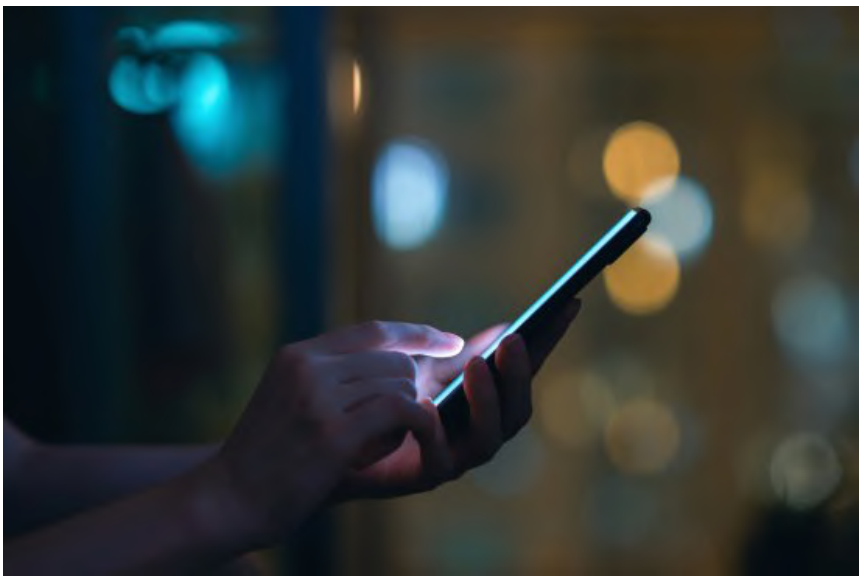
6 Red Flags About the Mental-Health Content You're Being Bombarded With on Social Media

Angela Haupt is a health and wellness editor at TIME. She covers happiness and actionable ways to live well.



The classic vision of therapy revolved around a person on a couch, supine, tapping into their deepest and darkest hopes and fears. A modern-day remix might look like this: a person still on a couch, but at home, scrolling through a constantly refreshing selection of mental-health content on social-media platforms like TikTok and Instagram.

Though it may feel therapeutic, experts advise proceeding with caution. As an increasing number of psychologists step into the role of mental-health influencer, opening the door to fame and financial incentives, their posts—on attachment styles or unresolved trauma or whatever else might be the disorder du jour—are reaching millions of people.

There are certainly benefits: "We're coming out of a time when mental health was very highly stigmatized, and it kept people from

seeking treatment," says Evelyn Hunter, a counseling psychologist in Auburn, Ala. "Social media has removed that in some ways, and normalized the fact that sometimes we struggle."

It can be difficult, however, to suss out which so-called experts are credible and whether their information is trustworthy—which can lead to misinformation and harmful misunderstandings. "The way information is so rapidly spread on social media can make it difficult to figure out what's accurate, what's professional, and what's expertise-driven," Hunter says. She stresses that mental-health professionals who are active on social media should demonstrate three qualities: competence, good-faith interpretation of evidence, and integrity.

With that in mind, if your algorithm is feeding you mental-health content, keep an eye out for these red flags.

1. The person running the account doesn't share their credentials.

Most credible mental-health influencers will be transparent about their training, licensure, and areas of expertise. The American Psychological Association (APA) Guidelines for the Optimal Use of Social Media in Professional Psychological Practice encourage psychologists to routinely update their personal and professional websites, and to monitor the information others have posted about them online and verify its accuracy.

For those of us looking to vet professionals, Victoria Riordan, an Ohio-based licensed professional clinical counselor with the counseling practice Thriveworks, suggests starting by checking the account's bio. That's where many practitioners specify whether they are, for example, a psychiatrist, social worker, or something else that perhaps doesn't require specific training or regulation, like

a life coach. They'll also likely include their area of expertise and link to a place where you can read more about them.

If you're not seeing much information, search the person's name online. If they're legitimate, "they're going to come up on Psychology Today, LinkedIn, or their own private practice website," Riordan says. "You're going to find them via several different sources, not just social media." You can also check to see if they're currently licensed, which is a vote of confidence in support of their education, experience, and ethical standards. Start with state licensing board websites or a resource like the Association of State and Provincial Psychology Boards.

2. They're trying to sell you something.

It's natural for psychologists to utilize their social-media platforms to promote things like online courses and books they've written, notes Genesis Games, a psychotherapist in Miami. "But if all their content leads you back to their storefront, that means they're more concerned about making you their customer than providing quality education," she says. "There's a difference between saying, 'These things are resources,'" and posting exclusively to hawk products.

The APA Ethics Code stresses that psychologists must avoid conflicts of interest. But these can still pop up online when people promote products—say, a supplement that allegedly alleviates anxiety—without disclosing a business relationship. If something feels off to you, trust your gut and do additional research, like Googling the person's name and the product and seeing what that search yields, Games suggests. Another telltale sign of a business relationship is if the company is routinely tagging the expert in its own social media posts.

In these situations, it's ultimately up to each consumer to do what feels best, Games says. As a first step, she recommends asking for clarification about the person's connection to a product, or simply

unfollowing them. But maybe you've stumbled upon an unfathomable claim or something that really bothers you. "If you think it's ill-intended or is putting others in severe danger," you could report the practitioner to the licensing board or college in the state where they practice, she says.

3. Posts are jargon-heavy.

Therapy speak is infiltrating everyday language. Talk about boundaries, repression, inner-child work, attachment styles, trauma, triggers—and much more—is tossed around frequently and casually. This overuse is concerning for a number of reasons, experts say. For one, people who don't fully understand the terms but see them on their social media feeds might be more likely to weaponize them in relationships to create a power dynamic. For another, in some cases latching onto and incorrectly using certain words "dilutes their meaning," says Mollie Spiesman, a licensed clinical social worker in New York.

She cautions social media users to keep an eye out for accounts that turn these types of therapy terms into buzzwords. Trust-worthy practitioners "typically aren't using therapy terms and therapy jargon, because they want to make therapy and mental health more approachable and digestible," she says. "If someone is trying to seem smarter than they are, or they're using all these terms that you don't understand, that's a red flag."

4. Practitioners promote self-diagnosis or labels.

A rule of thumb: Never diagnose yourself or others, Spiesman cautions. Social media is often fixated on labels: If you do these five things, you're depressed—or you're a narcissist or have ADHD or are on the autism spectrum. That can run counter to the APA's social media guidelines, which recommend psychologists

avoid offering diagnoses, giving advice, “or otherwise behaving as if they were conducting treatment.”

“What I notice with clients and friends is that people internalize these messages so deeply, and they do diagnose themselves,” Spiesman says. “They’ll see something on TikTok and be like, ‘Oh, I have this issue, or my partner has that.’” She now spends time in sessions asking clients to take a step back and reflect on why a specific post resonated with them so much.

5. They interact with clients on social media.

When Jeff Guenther, a licensed professional counselor based in Oregon, started to crave a creative outlet during the pandemic, he launched a TikTok account. Now, about two years later, he’s perhaps best known as his online alter ego—Therapy Jeff—and has accumulated nearly 3 million followers on TikTok and more than 850,000 on Instagram.

Guenther describes social media as the Wild West. He navigates it as carefully as possible by setting rules for himself—like not responding to existing clients who comment on his posts. Doing so could break confidentiality and blur the boundaries of the professional relationship, as the APA points out in its guidelines. “You have to tell your clients that you will ignore them, just like you would if you ran into them at the grocery store,” he says. So if you see a practitioner engaging with someone they’ve clearly worked with? Unfollow—it’s a red flag.

6. They tout one modality as superior to all others.

Therapists are typically trained in a number of different modalities, such as cognitive behavioral therapy, eye movement desensitization and reprocessing (EMDR), gestalt therapy, somatic therapy, and art therapy. They might specialize in and even prefer one, but they

shouldn’t be touting it online as the end-all, be-all, Games says. “Not one single therapeutic modality works for everyone,” she stresses. “It’s not one-size-fits-all.”

Games sometimes notices newer practitioners, in particular, emphasizing a certain treatment as though it’s a panacea. “Let’s say I keep getting content around EMDR, and I think, ‘I need to go find an EMDR therapist,’” she says. “So I try it, and it doesn’t feel good to me. Instead of thinking it’s just not the right treatment for me, I might think I’m the problem, and there’s something wrong with me, because it’s supposed to work and it’s not working.”

That drives home one of practitioners’ primary points about mental-health content on social media: Not every piece of information will apply to every person, so take it with a grain of salt. Therapists on social media are just that: therapists. They’re not *your* therapist.

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Mahsa Amini’s Death Still Haunts the Iranian Regime

Sadjadpour is a senior fellow at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace.

The Islamic Republic of Iran has thus far proved too ideologically rigid to reform and too ruthless to collapse. As in the late stages of the Soviet Union, however, the foundations decay in plain sight. Outside their homeland, women of Iranian origin become world-class mathematicians and astronauts; inside Iran, the ruling clerics debate whether women should be allowed to ride bicycles.

One year ago this month, the regime’s “morality police” detained and beat a 22-year-old woman—Mahsa Jina Amini—for allegedly showing too much hair beneath her compulsory veil. Her death in custody triggered Iran’s longest anti-government protests since the 1979 revolution that transformed the country from a U.S.-allied monarchy to an anti-American Islamist theocracy.

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Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei managed these protests as he always does, by crushing dissent, dividing adversaries, and refusing to offer any concessions. Over 20,000 people were arrested and over 500 killed, including several who were executed. Compromising under pressure, Khamenei believes, only projects weakness and emboldens dissent.

For the U.S., Iran's internal political dynamics have a direct bearing on national security. Viewed from Washington, Tehran is the world's leading state sponsor of terrorism, is actively trying to assassinate former U.S. officials (to avenge the 2019 killing of Iranian general Qasem Soleimani), provides Vladimir Putin lethal drones in his war against Ukraine, and has taken more U.S. citizens hostage than any other country in the world. At least five—who have collectively spent two decades as hostages in Tehran's Evin prison—could soon be returned to the U.S., in return for the U.S. unfreezing at least $6 billion in Iranian assets frozen in South Korea. There should be no illusions this deal will lead to a thaw in U.S.-Iran relations: senior Iranian officials—who publicly advocate hostage trading as an economic policy—have already announced the practice will continue.

A bigger challenge for the Biden Administration heading into election season is an advancing Iran nuclear program that could potentially trigger Israeli military action and skyrocketing oil prices. Five years after the Trump Administration withdrew from the 2015 Iran nuclear agreement signed by the Obama Administration, the CIA assesses that Tehran has the technical capacity to build nuclear weapons and is within weeks of having the fissile material to do so.

Going for a bomb, however, would be a risky move for Khamenei. Iran's nuclear sites have been thoroughly penetrated by Israel and the U.S., as evidenced by routine acts of sabotage reported at Iranian nuclear facilities and the assassination of top nuclear scientists. Khamenei's making the decision to weaponize also risks tilting the balance of power toward the Revolutionary Guards, who would likely control the nuclear codes (and aspire to control the country).

Successive U.S. administrations have sought to defuse Iran's nuclear program, and end the U.S.-Iran cold war, by either trying to engage the Iranian regime diplomatically or subjecting it to economic pressure in the hopes the regime will either capitulate or implode. None of these efforts has borne fruit. "Death to America" remains the Islamic Republic's enduring slogan.

But another pillar of the revolution is compulsory hijab. And a year after Amini's death, thousands of Iranian women defy these rules daily, despite the regime's use of Chinese facial-recognition technology to punish violations of laws of "hijab and chastity."

The country's economy is a shambles, and its former Minister of the Environment ominously warned that continued mismanagement of water resources could mean 50 million Iranians—70% of the country—"will have no choice but to leave the country." Climate scientists say parts of Iran (which this year reached temperatures of 152°F) could be the first places on earth too hot to be inhabited by humans.

After two decades of failure in Iraq and Afghanistan, and the disappointing outcomes of the 2011 Arab uprisings, the U.S. has little confidence that it can positively impact political outcomes in the Middle East. Indeed, absent a cohesive liberal opposition, an implosion of the Islamic Republic is less likely to be followed by an Iranian version of Jeffersonian democracy than by a military government.

For now, it remains a security state commanded by an octogenarian cleric who has held the title of Supreme Leader since 1989, before

most Iranians were born. “Everyone is just waiting,” a recent visitor from Tehran told me, “for the leader to die.”

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Why So Many of His Rivals See Ramaswamy as an Existential Threat

Philip Elliott is a senior correspondent at TIME, based in the Washington, D.C. bureau, where he covers national campaigns, elections, and government. He also writes TIME's politics newsletter, The D.C. Brief.

This article is part of The D.C. Brief, TIME's politics newsletter. Sign up here to get stories like this sent to your inbox.

To hear his rivals tell it, he's a neophyte charlatan unfit for the job he's seeking. A huckster with zero lines of his resume that are relevant to the job he's now pursuing. A gate-crashing fool who might be able to string together a few zingers, but hardly qualified to open the nuclear football with wisdom or shut down a stock market with credibility. A danger to the post-World War 2 world order, someone who would surrender to Moscow and fling almost a century of foreign-policy convention into a woodchipper, a chump who just doesn't get it. Or maybe worse of all, the second coming of the most derided figure on the American political right: Barack Obama.

Eight years ago, that should have been the argument against Donald Trump, a norm-breaking cautionary flag against amateurism. The Republican Party couldn't figure out how to disqualify a candidate who, by traditional benchmarks, was as unqualified as they'd seen since Ike. This week, on a debate stage in Milwaukee, it was the indictment against Vivek Ramaswamy. The 38-year-old tech bro who was the surprising bullseye of the first Republican presidential debate and, unexpectedly, a source of unmitigated contempt from some of his fellow candidates.

Maybe it was Ramaswamy's consistent and confounding defense of All Things Trump. Maybe it was his smooth talk and culture-war acumen. Maybe it was just the fact that Ramaswamy frankly does not care how things were done before and might just have enough self-made money to go the distance.

Former New Jersey Gov. Chris Christie snarled that he had "had enough already tonight of a guy who sounds like ChatGPT," an A.I. battery. He then dismissed Ramaswamy as someone on the same level as a political figure universally loathed in the GOP. "The last person in one of these debates… who stood in the middle of the stage and said, 'What is a skinny guy with an odd last name doing up here?' was Barack Obama. And I am afraid we are dealing with the same type of amateur standing on the stage tonight," Christie said.

Sniped former South Carolina Gov. Nikki Haley: "You have no foreign policy experience, and it shows."

And, in a sign that former Vice President Mike Pence understands his esteem with those on Team MAGA is low, he took a jab at Ramaswamy and the very characteristic that helped originally elevate Trump in the minds of so many in the GOP base.

"Now it's not the time for on-the-job training," retorted Pence. "We don't need to bring in a rookie. We don't need to bring in people

with no experience.”

Attacks during debates are the norm but this was different. Ramaswamy’s competitors really don’t like him. Not even a little.

But that probably wasn’t viewed as a bad thing to Ramaswamy, who isn’t interested in being one of those candidates who, despite being a rival, folks just like. He—and it’s always a he to this point—is a popular figure backstage, someone everyone seeks out to just greet and to see what’s good. Most folks understood that former Massachusetts Gov. Deval Patrick wasn’t a real threat in 2020, but they all wanted to check in with him because he is among the sharpest minds in the Democratic Party on civil rights. Four years earlier, everyone liked to hear the musings of Sen. Lindsey Graham of South Carolina; he always had a story about something that could elicit a low-stakes giggle in the wings of a cattle call. And four years before that, no one would accuse former Minnesota Gov. Tim Pawlenty of showboating. There is a value in being a decent human being, even if that all-too-rare quality seldom ends in political success.

Ramaswamy? Well, no one is credibly thinking this guy is going to win Mr. Congeniality. His rivals have skipped right past the open-palm slap and moved right to the sucker punch. He has already gotten under the skin of his competitors in a way that invokes John Kerry’s contempt of Howard Dean in 2004 or George H.W. Bush’s ire with Pat Buchanan in 1992. Sometimes, there’s just one kid in the class who needs to be thwacked for good measure.

It’s hard to argue that Ramaswamy, who has never before run for anything at this level, is a real factor in this race. As much as he tried to channel Obama on the debate stage, the charisma just isn’t there. Yet.

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And that *yet* is why so many of Ramaswamy's rivals decided it was worth their time to slag him Wednesday night. They all remember 2016, and how pretending Trump wasn't a factor allowed him to coast for long enough to establish himself as a credible and bemusing enough figure to start a march to the nomination and then to the White House. Lesson learned, Ramaswamy's rivals were not going to make that mistake again.

Of course, the GOP race is still Trump's to lose. He's polling at least 30 points ahead of his closest rival, Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis. But DeSantis has slogged through one of the worst stretches any White House hopeful has seen in recent memory.

Still, the fact that Ramaswamy merited any oppo prep says a lot about the field. In normal times, he would not be a factor, an interloper with zero experience who should not matter. But the reboot of politics in the last 20 years has made his candidacy possible. Mike Bloomberg rode his money to become the mayor of the nation's largest city and tried to steer his way to the White House the same way. Trump leveraged celebrity and perceived wealth to the White House. Ramaswamy, an investing juggernaut in his own telling, thinks he could follow that mold to heave himself into the Oval Office.

As implausible as it sounds, Ramaswamy mightn't be completely delusional. The GOP has long fetishized wealth, leaving it as a proxy for actual talent. Actual experience is secondary in both parties. And America is still reeling from four years of Trump in the White House. If the United States could weather that hurricane, who's to say it isn't willing to experiment with a knock-off Trump, one who doesn't have four indictments hanging over him?

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These Are the Shots You Should Get This Fall and Winter

Alice Park is a senior health correspondent at TIME. She covers the COVID-19 pandemic, new drug developments in cancer and Alzheimer's disease, mental health, HIV, CRISPR, and advances in gene therapy, among other issues in health and science. She also covers the Olympics, and co-chaired TIME's inaugural TIME 100 Health Summit in 2019. Her work has won awards from the New York Press Club, and recognition from the Deadline Club. In addition, she is the author of *The Stem Cell Hope: How Stem Cell Medicine Can Change Our Lives*.

It used to be relatively easy and straightforward to navigate the fall and winter respiratory disease season in the U.S.—get a flu shot. Then came COVID-19, and another vaccine was added to the mix.

Now, for the first time, there will be a third shot for some groups: a vaccine for respiratory syncytial virus (RSV), which causes respiratory disease that can be especially dangerous for infants and older people.

Here’s what experts say about who should be receiving which shots, and when.

Flu (the easy one)

The advice here is straightforward and the same as it’s always been: “Everybody should be getting a flu shot,” says Dr. Paul Offit, professor of pediatrics and director of the Vaccine Education Center at Children’s Hospital of Philadelphia, and a member of the U.S. Food and Drug Administration’s (FDA) expert vaccine committee.

Everybody, that is, who is eligible, which the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) defines as anyone six months or older.

The flu vaccine’s efficacy varies widely from year to year, since health officials have to make their best guess about which strains of influenza will be circulating months ahead of time, in order to give the vaccine makers enough time to produce the shot. Historically, the seasonal flu shot has been 40% to 60% effective in protecting people from getting sick with the flu, according to the CDC. Each year, about half of people who are eligible in the U.S. get vaccinated, although rates are lower among some groups, including among Black and Hispanic adults, for a variety of reasons, including inequitable access to health services, cultural barriers and skepticism about vaccines.

Even though most people feel they can shake off flu symptoms in a few days, it’s worth remembering that the viral infection can be dangerous and even deadly for those with chronic health conditions. According to the CDC, from 2010 to 2020, flu sent 140,000 to 710,000 people to the hospital annually, most of whom were 65 years or older, and contributed to 12,000 to 79,000 deaths each year.

The latest COVID-19 variants and vaccines

There will be an updated COVID-19 vaccine in mid-September, but U.S. health officials have not yet decided which specific SARS-CoV-2 strain the shot will target. In June, the FDA's independent panel of vaccine experts decided that the vaccine should be updated from its current version, which targets Omicron variants BA.4 and BA.5. The committee recommended moving to a new variant, from the XBB family, which was causing the majority of infections at the time—and, following guidance from the World Health Organization, the panel also advised that the updated vaccine target only one XBB strain, rather than two as the BA.4/5 shot did. The committee members suggested that vaccine manufacturers should focus on XBB.1.5, so Moderna, Pfizer and Novavax began developing and manufacturing those doses in time for fall.

Since then, newer variants have emerged, including EG.5, FL.1.5.1, and BA.2.86. But Moderna, Novavax, and Pfizer all say that early tests show their XBB shots can also neutralize the latest variants. In Moderna's case, the data comes from early tests in people, while Novavax and Pfizer have so far only reported results in animal studies.

Once the FDA decides which strain the updated vaccine will contain, the CDC's Advisory Committee for Immunization Practices will issue guidance on who should get it, and when. Not all experts believe everyone should receive the updated shot. Offit, for example, says most healthy people who have already had their primary series of the original vaccine and at least one booster dose, and likely also gotten infected at some point over the past few years, probably won't need another booster. That's based on data showing that the original vaccine combined with the first booster provided nearly as much protection as the updated booster targeting BA.4 and BA.5—and which Offit and others believe will continue

to protect people from getting severely ill from the newest COVID-19 variants

The reason for that has to do with the T-cell immune response built up from those earlier versions of the shots. T-cells produce a long-lasting form of protection that's designed to remember previous infections and mount stronger and quicker responses against things like viruses when people are exposed to them again. That's because these cells focus on parts of the virus that are more conserved, or shared among different variants. And the recent variants are about 80% similar to the original strains, says Offit.

However, if scientists begin to see the virus mutating in a way that makes it harder for the T-cells of previously vaccinated people to recognize—or if data start to show that people who are hospitalized are more likely to be those who have not received the BA.4/5 booster, then that would make a case for giving the updated vaccine to more people.

For now, it's likely that the updated vaccine will provide the most benefit to people who are most vulnerable to COVID-19 complications, such as the elderly, and those with chronic health conditions that weaken their immune systems.

RSV is the newest seasonal vaccine

For certain groups of people, there may be another shot in store for them this fall, since for the first time, there are FDA-approved ways to prevent RSV infections. RSV generally affects older people and infants, sending around 58,000 children under five to the hospital in the U.S. each year, and contributing to 14,000 deaths annually among those 65 or older.

The first of these shots is a vaccine, made by Pfizer, approved for people 60 years and older, and for pregnant people 32 to 36 weeks into their pregnancy. GlaxoSmithKline also received FDA approval

for its RSV vaccine for people 60 years and older. The second is a monoclonal antibody, called nirsevimab and made by Sanofi and AstraZeneca, which is approved for babies under eight months old. It's not a vaccine, since it does not stimulate the babies' immune systems to produce the antibodies like a vaccine does; instead, it simply injects these antibodies into their bloodstream in a single shot.

"We went from nothing to an abundance of riches," says Dr. Cody Meissner, professor of pediatrics at Dartmouth Geisel School of Medicine and one of the FDA's vaccine committee experts. "It's really bringing us into a new era." Meissner is also part of CDC's vaccine group that is currently discussing how to guide physicians about using those new options.

That new world may come with quite a bit of confusion, however, at least at first. The question of whether to get vaccinated is pretty straightforward for people 60 or older—the shot can reduce the risk of hospitalization by around 80%.

The situation is more complicated for pregnant people and babies, however. The vaccine has been approved for pregnant people 32-36 weeks into the pregnancy, and the CDC is weighing whether to recommend it for all women in that group, or for certain women and their babies who might be more vulnerable to RSV when they are born, such as premature infants and those born with chronic lung conditions. The discussion was prompted by concerns about the potential risk of premature births associated with the shot that studies of the vaccine revealed.

In the Pfizer studies that led to FDA approval, among women who received the vaccine, there was a slightly higher percentage who gave birth early, before 37 weeks (5.7%), than among those who got a placebo, (4.7%). But the difference was not statistically significant. Still, that trend is potentially more concerning when coupled with the fact that another pharmaceutical company,

GlaxoSmithKline, stopped developing a maternal RSV vaccine very similar to Pfizer's after its studies found a statistically significant risk of preterm births associated with the shot. "One of two things could be true," says Offit. "Either both have the same problem, and Pfizer hasn't found it yet, or neither has a problem." While there isn't an obvious reason why the vaccine would contribute to premature delivery, the RSV protein targeted by the vaccine can trigger inflammatory reactions that could increase the risk for preterm birth.

The Pfizer study included women who were at least at 24 weeks of gestation. Because the risk of premature birth overall decreases the later into gestation, the FDA approved it for pregnant people beyond 32 weeks, when the risk of early delivery is lower.

The CDC's working group is trying to figure out whether to recommend the vaccine for all expectant mothers, given this risk. "We are having more meetings about this than any other vaccine in my memory," says Meissner. It's unlikely, given the cost of the vaccine (up to $295) and the monoclonal antibody treatment, ($495 for the lowest dose for the smallest infants), that a pregnant woman would receive the vaccine and then have her baby get the antibody injection. "That's duplicating responsibilities," he says. "Like wearing suspenders and a belt. So we are in the process of sorting out, with weekly Zoom calls, how these would be used."

Until then, Meissner says doctors need to discuss the potential risks with women, even if Pfizer's data do not show a statistically significant danger of preterm births. "My personal opinion is a mother needs to be honestly told that this rate [of giving birth prematurely] is slightly higher with this vaccine," he says. That conversation won't be easy, especially for busy obstetricians who may not have the time to delve into the complicated nature of the data.

Over the next few months, health experts will be eager to see how effective the newest options are in curbing infections and, more importantly, reducing severe disease and keeping people out of the hospital. Pfizer says it plans to have adequate supply of its new RSV vaccine for both pregnant and older people in time for the fall (a spokesperson says vials labeled for older people can also be used for those who are pregnant until the new labeling is available).

But the updated and new vaccines, and the RSV antibody, will only have an impact if people have access to them. While the public health emergency for COVID-19 has ended, most insurers will continue to cover the updated COVID-19 vaccine, along with the flu shot. Certain Medicare plans will cover the RSV shot for older people, while the CDC has included both the maternal RSV vaccine and the antibody in its Vaccines for Children Program, which means that the government will provide these for families who are uninsured or cannot afford them.

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What Prigozhin’s Death Reveals About Putin’s Power in Russia

Sebag-Montefiore is the bestselling author of many books, including Jerusalem and The Romanovs. His new book is The World: A Family History of Humanity

The predictability of brazenly atrocious and baroque violence in Russian court politics does not make it less shocking when it actually happens. And this week it has happened in all senses with a fiery vengeance.

“Are you able to forgive?” an interviewer asked President Vladimir Putin in March 2018. “Yes, but not everything,” he replied.

“What is it impossible to forgive?”

“Betrayal,” replied Putin, speaking as a Russian spy who had worked for the British, Sergei Skripal, lay apparently dying after being poisoned in Salisbury, England by Russian assassins.

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This week, it seems it was the turn Yevgeny Prigozhin, the billionaire oligarch, catering tycoon, mercenary chieftain, and recent mutineer, when his private jet was either blown up by a bomb or was shot down. He is presumed to have been killed. Prigozhin was the head of the Wagner mercenary force and its commander Dmitry Utkin and other Wagernians (nicknamed the Musicians on military Telegram accounts) were also aboard the plane. As was a young and completely innocent air hostess named Kristina Raspopova—another victim of careless Russian potentates.

But as usual in today's Russia, we know very little about what is really happening within the tiny inner circle of the Putin court. It is clear that so far even supposed "security experts" are just reading the same Telegram accounts as the rest of us. We have not seen Prigozhin's body and his death cannot be confirmed but both the Russian state and Wagner sources say he is dead—so he most probably is no longer amongst the living.

Given the rules of power in Putinist Russia, no one is surprised that Prigozhin was killed, only that the interval between his mutiny and his killing was so long—two months—and so tortuously inconsistent that it exposed the weakness of Putin. Russian rulers are experts in targeted violence that can be both entirely predictable but kinetically surprising.

The rise and fall of Prigozhin reveals many threads that run throughout Russian history and remain acutely relevant now. It also chronicles the depletion of autocratic prestige, state power, and competent management, and it further raises the threat of the disintegration of Russia itself.

First, all of this is a symptom of personal power, one man rule, the habitual system of autocracy in Russia throughout its long history.

One cannot say dictatorship is the only way Russia could have developed and that democracy is impossible; far from it, but its tendency is overwhelming. Putin has shaped a modern version of autocracy, held together by his personal power, ability to play off his potentates, and offer glory and stability to his people. His decision to “roll the iron dice”—Bismarck’s great expression—of war has not only led to the death of an estimated 500,000 people, many of them innocent Ukrainian civilians, but also placed his own rule under impossible stress, revealing a decaying state dominated by coercion, feuding, incompetence, mendacity, and venality.

Yet it turned out Putin was inept at running his own court and could not prevent Kremlin rivalries playing out online and then exploding into open rebellion on 23 June 2023 when Prigozhin led his forces to seize Rostov and then advance on Moscow. We may never know the real deal brokered by Putin’s client Belarusian dictator Alexander Lukashenko to stop the advance, but Putin, ashen and lacking his trademark swagger, was forced to go on TV to denounce Prigozhin’s treason. Russian rulers are accustomed to face rebellions and crush them but they generally did so with considerably more elan—and more vivid violence. Peter the Great rushed back from his Great Embassy to Europe to torture thousands of rebel musketeers in specially-constructed torture chambers. Catherine the Great unleashed her generals to crush the Pugachev rebellion—they sailed floating gallows down the Volga. Nicholas I facing the mutiny of elite Guards regiments in the streets of Petersburg bombarded them with artillery. Putin acquiesced in Lukashenko’s shadowy agreement and even met Prigozhin who was allowed to fly around the world, recently visiting his Musicians in Africa, wielding a Kalashnikov and full desert fatigues.

The rise of Prigozhin (‘Putin’s chef’, ‘hotdog-seller’) is not some exotic freak of nature: he is just the latest in a long line of court favourites whose ascendancies are the inevitable result of personal power at its most supreme. Some imperial favourites were amazingly talented—Catherine the Great’s co-ruler Prince Potemkin was the greatest statesman of the Romanov dynasty—and some not—Nicholas II’s Rasputin was the most talentless. But when these favourites lose the protection of their patron, their falls are vertiginous for their power and wealth arouse vicious jealousy amongst the traditional elites. The great favourite of the last reign, Boris Berezovsky, a Jewish mathematician charmed the ursine, cantankerous, crapulous President Boris Yeltsin and vitally his influential daughter Tatiana, with his nervy worldly dynamic style, made billions from owning Sibneft and Aeroflot. Fatally he played some role in anointing Yeltsin’s successor, Putin, who swiftly resented Berezovsky’s presumptuous interference. Escaping into exile, his death reportedly by hanging in the bathroom of his Surrey mansion may have been either a howl of despair or an efficient mission by Putin’s assassins. (The British police have been cloddishly slow to realize that Russian agents were using all methods, including efficient poisons, to kill victims in Britain.)

Prigozhin, one of Putin's St Peterburg circle, received massive financial prizes: catering and later military contracts worth billions. But he was also one of more energetic and competent managers that Putin trusted: it was he who set up the troll-farms Putin used to undermined the democracy of the Chief Enemy (America) and it was he who helped create the Wagner mercenary group that allowed Russia to run a cost effective and aggressive but deniable foreign policy. Who can forget the amazing sight of Russian mercenaries fighting their way across the Syrian desert to take the ancient city of Palmyra, once in ancient times the capital of Empress Zenobia and her Middle Eastern empire? When Putin launched his wars against Ukraine, initially in 2014, then fullscale in 2022, and the military turned out to be ill-led and ill-supplied, Prigozhin provided his vicious Wagner stormtroopers who distinguished themselves with their resilience and atrocities. Emulating Stalin's use of convict conscripts in his Shtrafbats in WWII, he recruited in prisons. He had deserters executed with sledgehammers, glorying in violence justified by nationalism. That was where Prigozhin intensified his feud with Putin's long serving magnates Defense Minister Shoigu and Chief of Staff Gerasimov. Putin's failure to control that feud has exposed his own limits.

Prigozhin became the condottiere of his own private army, funded by the state. He was not the only one: the Chechen ruler Ramzan Kadyrov is also effectively a warlord with his own private forces. It is a sign of Russia's weakening state that Putin allowed non-state players to command their own armies in the first place.

Read More: What Comes After Putin's Rule in Russia

Prigozhin's criminal background—he served time in prison and seems to have killed someone in his youth—was another feature of the Russian power culture. It was the Bolsheviks who merged criminal culture with that of the state. The revolutionary Sergei Nechayev had declared in his 1869 Revolutionary Catechism that "We must unite with the world of adventurous gangs of criminals,

the only genuine revolutionists in Russia”—an idea that influenced Lenin, Stalin, and their generation.

Once in power, they endowed their new secret police the Chekas with powers of arbitrary violence unthinkable in the era of the tsars. The Romanovs under Nicholas I had invented modern secret police organs but for all their violent suppression of rebellions, they rarely assassinated enemies or traitors outside or inside Russia. Lenin and Stalin disdained their softness: the end always justified the means. Before power Stalin raised cash in spectacular bank robberies and protection rackets while liquidating traitors. In power, their Cheka harnessed the esprit of a military-religious order of knights with the atrocious violence of a gangster hit squad. Even as Cheka developed into a vast bureaucracy of the NKVD and later the KGB, it became the elite corps of Soviet state. When the Soviet Union collapsed, KGB officers, now working for the new organs the FSB and the SVR, regarded themselves as knights—what their director, and now one of Putin’s top henchmen, Nikolai Patrushev, called a new nobility but it was a nobility that encompassed the corruption, greed and murderousness of a Mafia family.

President Putin himself revelled in that culture—his swaggering threat to liquidate Chechen terrorists “even sitting on the lav” was a deliberate statement of that murderous machismo. In the secret police and intelligence organs, there is a special prestige to assassinations which are known vividly as мокроедело, *mokroye delo* (Wet Work).

The mechanism whereby Putin orders killings—and to what extent they are signed off on paper or by secret verbal orders and to what extent they are perpetrated by courtiers seeking to win favour— is unknown of course. Sometimes Putin is likely to be involved in planning such operations; other times not. We do not know. Sometimes the killers may be Chechens maybe organized by Putin’s other feral favourite, his tributary ruler of Russia’s Chechen

republic, Kadyrov. Sometimes the killers are FSB or GRU spies; other times gangster hitmen on semi-official business.

In the case of Prigozhin—if indeed he is dead and if this was the work of a missile it would have required coordination between FSN or the military intelligence GU to ensure that the right people were on the private jet and the Air Defence, not an organization frequently used for Wet Work, to bring it down. A bomb is simpler.

Russian rulers must always exist in a state of ferocious vigilance. The direction of secret police organs is almost their first duty and perennial interest. But also espionage is thrilling for leaders— it is one of the exciting parts of the job for any leader, even in democracies. Stalin personally ran the organs himself, directing everything through henchmen, most famously two NKVD commissars, Nikolai Yezhov, who was untalented, unstable and always out of his depth, and Lavrenti Beria, his fellow Georgian who was highly capable, efficient and sadistic—and almost managed to succeed Stalin as Soviet leader. But Stalin's NKVD potentates were much more important than Prigozhin— they managed vast organs and many millions of people.

Stalin believed killing was an invaluable political tool—boasting to his Bulgarian ally Georgi Dmitrov—"we do it by bloodletting"—

but he was also fascinated by Wet Work, enjoying the devising the complex murder plots such as the killing in a “car accident” of the beloved Yiddish Soviet actor Solomon Mikhoels who was actually kidnapped, given a fatal injection and then placed n the street to look like the victim of a car crash.

The violence that Prigozhin flaunted was very much a part of Putinist culture as it was in Stalin’s time: Putin has never approached the scale of repression that Stalin unleashed during collectivisation, his famines and then his Terror. The death toll runs into untold millions—it will never be exactly known. It is a different time now and Putin is not Stalin in many ways. But targetted killing has always been part of his system: his accession saw a spiral of killings of his enemies or inconveniences to his power, from that of Galina Starovoitnova, the Duma member who promoted western democracy when he was still FBS director, to Anna Politovskaya, the investigative journalist, in 2006 and ex-deputy-premier and critic Boris Nemtsov in 2015, and famously the poisoning of his chief opposition Alexei Navalny in 2020. While abroad dissidents and double-agents from Alexander Litvinenko to Sergei Skripal were targeted for murder with exotic poisons from the biological weapons laboratory.

Since the Ukraine war started, destabilizing and reshaping the secretive tournament of rivals and clans into a frenzied cagefight for money and power, the killing spiral has become unpredictable and widespread: bankers, oil executives, bureaucrats—and sometimes as a gruesome warning, their mistresses—have been murdered—thrown out of windows, drowned in pools, poisoned. Many businessman who expressed skepticism about Putin’s war now found that their rivals—who many well have been FSB potentates—could forcefully grab their companies and sometimes liquidate them, too.

Putin proudly declared in 2018 that betrayal of the secret services was unforgivable and however long it takes, the state and the

Organs will take vengeance. Putin and his Chekist potentates adopted the old Stalinist rule that any traitor must be hunted down and killed. The secret police always followed this rule, even spreading the rumour that the ’60s double agent GRU Colonel Oleg Pentkovsky was executed by being incinerated alive at a secret police crematorium in a ceremony attended by selected officers. It may even be true.

Every autocrat identifies totally with the state and its servants: Putin does not need to choose between state and personal betrayal. But treason is even more bitter if the traitor is a personal friend and protégé like Prigozhin. Peter the Great was outraged by the betrayal of his close long-serving ally Ivan Mazeppa, the Ukrainian Cossack Hetman of Zaporizhian Host and Left-Bank Ukraine for twenty years. His story is very relevant today. Mazeppa feared that Peter was about to grant the Hetmanate to his intimate Russian friend Prince Menshikov so when the Swedish King Charles XII invaded Ukraine in 1708, Mazeppa agonized what to do. Charles offered him independence. Mazeppa defected to the Swedes. Peter was incensed and sent Menshikov to liquidate everyone in Mazeppa’s capital. He was keen to kill Mazeppa too but the Hetman died of natural causes soon after he and Charles lost the battle of Poltava in 1709.

Even more personal was the betrayal of Peter by his own eldest son who plotted against him and then defected, escaping to Vienna in 1716. Peter lured him back promising security—but on his return he tortured him to death. Peter is Putin’s hero. Photographs of his sumptuous yacht were revealed by opposition researchers online and even there he had a statuette of the first emperor of Russia. No matter how close the traitor, the traitor had to die.

Prigozhin was an intimate courtier of Putin and it seems that Putin continued to protect Prigozhin even when he was ranting in his baritone roar against Shoigu and Gerasimov as they played political games, starving his Wagnerians of ammunition and support. But

sometime in the meatgrinder of Bakhmut, the desperate fray turned his head: Prigozhin started to identify himself and his Wagner troopers as blood-spattered heroes of Russia's war against Ukraine—and anyone who held them back as traitors to the Motherland—even Shoigu, maybe even the President himself. Some of the Russian Army's best fighting generals—General Armageddon Surovikin the most prominent—sympathized with Prigozhin and despised the cowards at headquarters.

The rebellion of June 23 this year crossed every line. It was a humiliation for the President. Not just the personal betrayal of Putin's protégé on whom he and the state had showered billions but also a political betrayal that exposed to the world the incompetence and corruption of Putin's command and conduct of the war. Putin spoke of Prigozhin with almost paternal sadness like a son he had had to sacrifice: "I have known Prigozhin from the beginning of the 1990s," Putin said with a strange wistfulness. "He was a man with a complex fate. Sometimes he made mistakes; sometimes he got results–for himself and in response to my requests, for a common cause. He was a talented person."

No one believed Prigozhin would remain amongst the living for long. Putin could not punish Prigozhin until the Wagner group was pacified and until he had identified, arrested, and dismissed any sympathetic generals. It seems Surovikin was arrested and sacked as commander of air defence the day before Prigozhin flew too close to the sun.

Then Putin received Prigozhin at a meeting of Wagner commanders. That must have taken some of his arctic self control. He allowed Prigozhin to appear on the sidelines of his conference with African leaders, many of whom would have known the condottiere since Wagner troops were present in their countries. A week ago, Prigozhin was reportedly in Africa, probably Mali boasting that Wagner was "making Russia even greater on all continents, and Africa even more free." He growled that "the

temperature is plus 50 degrees Celsius" in Mali but he did not realize it was getting even hotter at home…

It is said that the FSB had urged Putin to let him liquidate Prigozhin at once; Putin was more cautious. There were loose ends to tie up. But also there was something else there: he was teasing the loudmouthed braggart Prigozhin, letting him feel safe and preen on his online channels, even flaunt that he was still alive, still in business. Stalin did the same with his enemies such Nikolai Bukharin who reflected sadly that Stalin was a "master of dosage." Putin too is a master of dosage.

It seems that Putin has deliberately beheaded the snake that is Wagner. Presumably its troops will be broken up or signed up by more reliable mercenary outfits. It is unknown who will take over Wagner's role as Russia's African vanguard.

In Russia, the mystique of power—from Peter the Great to Lavrenti Beria and on to Putin today—is often won by the capricious deployment of violence: now with this killing, Putin has to some extent restored his mastery. If Prigozhin was indeed on the plane this was an execution plain and simple. It was not just a bullet in the head but a spectacular strike. It was a state hit—Wet Work gone large. Yet this turbulence in the inner circle, the rise of warlords, the open feuding, the killings, the rebellion by a protégé, now the execution of a courtier by his master—all of this augers ill for

Russia and presages the deterioration of the Russian state. Perhaps even a new Smuta—the Time of Troubles that almost destroyed Russia in the civil wars of 1598-1613 and again in 1918-21.

One man one problem, no man no problem—as Stalin and his henchmen put it. Есть человек — есть проблема, нет человека—нет проблемы. Except in this case many problems remain. The war for a start. Wagnerites may seek their own vengeance: what if they have admirers in say Putin's bodyguards? And amongst his exploits Prigozhin has broken Putin's myth of invulnerability and the taboo against elite revolt. Ultimately if the tsar stumbles it will be those closest who wield the dagger.

Here the president and officials of a huge empire and powerful nuclear-armed intergalactic modern state conspiring to liquidate one of their own intimates, behaving like narco-trafficantes or the cutthroats of a small town in Renaissance Italy. Yet So far Russia 's grandees and people are rallying to the Motherland and its ruler; its huge army is holding.

Putin is the master again of violence but he is damaged. Yet a weakened tyrant can rule for a long time. And war grinds on…

Simon Sebag Montefiore is the author most recently of The World: A Family History of Humanity and earlier of The Romanovs and Stalin: Court of the Red Tsar

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She Wasn’t Able to Get an Abortion. Now She’s a Mom. Soon She’ll Start 7th Grade.

Charlotte Alter is a senior correspondent at TIME. She covers politics, social movements, and generational change, and hosts TIME's Person of the Week podcast. She is also the author of *The Ones We've Been Waiting For: How a New Generation of Leaders Will Transform America*. Her work for TIME has won a Front Page Award from the Newswoman's Club of New York and has been nominated for a GLAAD Media award.

Ashley just had a baby. She’s sitting on the couch in a relative’s apartment in Clarksdale, Miss., wearing camo-print leggings and fiddling with the plastic hospital bracelets still on her wrists. It’s August and pushing 90 degrees, which means the brown patterned curtains are drawn, the air conditioner is on high, and the room feels like a hiding place. Peanut, the baby boy she delivered two days earlier, is asleep in a car seat at her feet, dressed in a little blue outfit. Ashley is surrounded by family, but nobody is smiling. One relative silently eats lunch in the kitchen, her two siblings stare glumly at their phones, and her mother, Regina, watches from across the room. Ashley was discharged from the hospital only

hours ago, but there are no baby presents or toys in the room, no visible diapers or ointments or bottles. Almost nobody knows that Peanut exists, because almost nobody knew that Ashley was pregnant. She is 13 years old. Soon she'll start seventh grade.

In the fall of 2022, Ashley was raped by a stranger in the yard outside her home, her mother says. For weeks, she didn't tell anybody what happened, not even her mom. But Regina knew something was wrong. Ashley used to love going outside to make dances for her TikTok, but suddenly she refused to leave her bedroom. When she turned 13 that November, she wasn't in the mood to celebrate. "She just said, 'It hurts,'" Regina remembers. "She was crying in her room. I asked her what was wrong, and she said she didn't want to tell me." (To protect the privacy of a juvenile rape survivor, TIME is using pseudonyms to refer to Ashley and Regina; Peanut is the baby's nickname.)

The signs were obvious only in retrospect. Ashley started feeling sick to her stomach; Regina thought it was related to her diet. At one point, Regina even asked Ashley if she was pregnant, and Ashley said nothing. Regina hadn't yet explained to her daughter how a baby is made, because she didn't think Ashley was old enough to understand. "They need to be kids," Regina says. She doesn't think Ashley even realized that what happened to her could lead to a pregnancy.

On Jan. 11, Ashley began throwing up so much that Regina took her to the emergency room at Northwest Regional Medical Center in Clarksdale. When her bloodwork came back, the hospital called the police. One nurse came in and asked Ashley, "What have you been doing?" Regina recalls. That's when they found out Ashley was pregnant. "I broke down," Regina says.

Dr. Erica Balthrop was the ob-gyn on call that day. Balthrop is an assured, muscular woman with close-cropped cornrows and a tattoo of a feather running down her arm. She ordered an ultrasound, and determined Ashley was 10 or 11 weeks along. “It was surreal for her,” Balthrop recalls. “She just had no clue.” The doctor could not get Ashley to answer any questions, or to speak at all. “She would not open her mouth.” (Balthrop spoke about her patient’s medical history with Regina’s permission.)

At their second visit, about a week later, Regina tentatively asked Balthrop if there was any way to terminate Ashley’s pregnancy. Seven months earlier, Balthrop could have directed Ashley to abortion clinics in Memphis, 90 minutes north, or in Jackson, Miss., two and a half hours south. But today, Ashley lives in the heart of abortion-ban America. In 2018, Republican lawmakers in Mississippi enacted a ban on most abortions after 15 weeks of pregnancy. The law was blocked by a federal judge, who ruled that it violated the abortion protections guaranteed by *Roe v. Wade.* The Supreme Court felt differently. In their June 2022 decision in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization*, the Supreme Court overturned the constitutional right to abortion that had existed for nearly half a century. Within weeks, Mississippi and every state that borders it banned abortion in almost all circumstances.

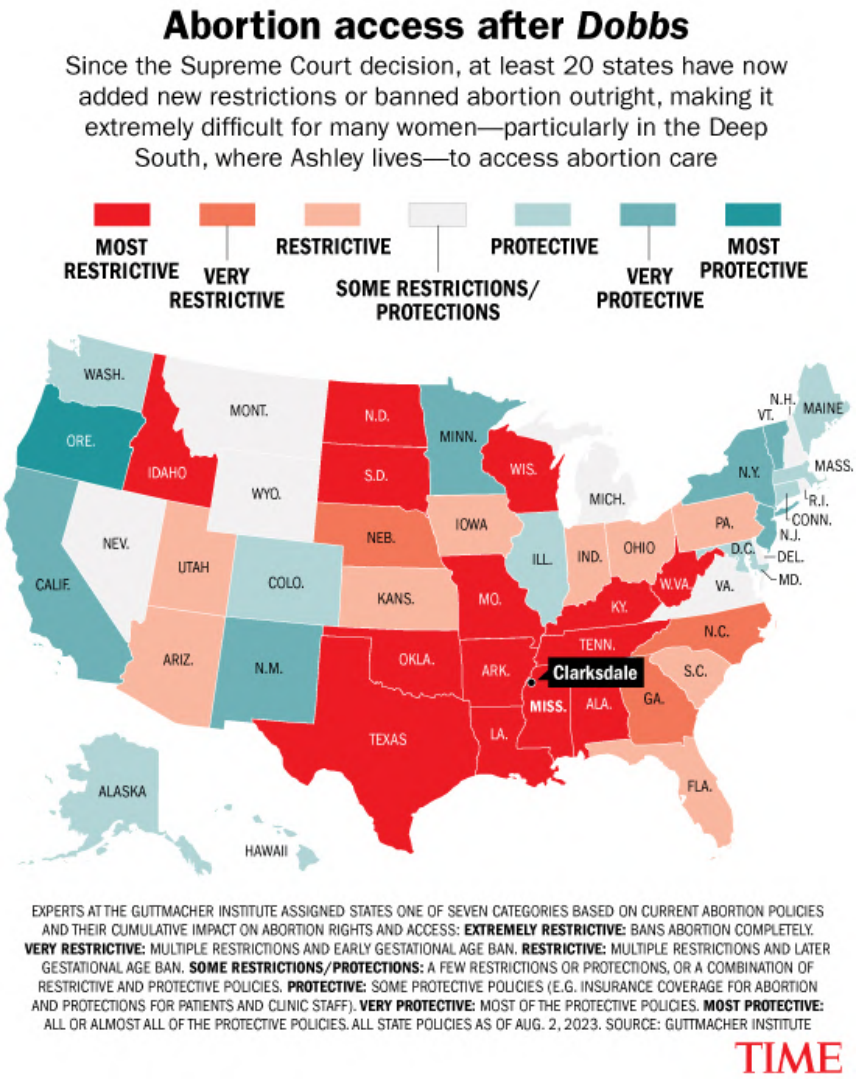
Balthrop told Regina that the closest abortion provider for Ashley would be in Chicago. At first, Regina thought she and Ashley could drive there. But it's a nine-hour trip, and Regina would have to take off work. She'd have to pay for gas, food, and a place to stay for a couple of nights, not to mention the cost of the abortion itself. "I don't have the funds for all this," she says.

So Ashley did what girls with no other options do: she did nothing.

Clarksdale is in the Mississippi Delta, a vast stretch of flat, fertile land in the northwest corner of the state, between the Mississippi and Yazoo rivers. The people who live in the Delta are overwhelmingly Black. The poverty rate is high. The region is an epicenter of America's ongoing Black maternal-health crisis. Mississippi has the second-highest maternal-mortality rate in the country, with 43 deaths per 100,00 live births, and the Delta has among the worst maternal-healthcare outcomes in the state. Black women in Mississippi are four times as likely to die from pregnancy-related complications as white women.

Mississippi's abortion ban is expected to result in thousands of additional births, often to low-income, high-risk mothers. Dr. Daniel Edney, Mississippi's top health official, tells TIME his department is "actively preparing" for roughly 4,000 additional live

births this year alone. Edney says improving maternal-health outcomes is the “No. 1 priority” for the Mississippi health department, which has invested $2 million into its Healthy Moms, Healthy Babies program to provide extra support for new mothers. “There is a sense of following through, and not just as a predominantly pro-life state,” says Edney. “We don’t just care about life in utero. We care about life, period, and that includes the mother’s life and the baby’s life.”



Mississippi’s abortion ban contains narrow exceptions, including for rape victims and to save the life of the mother. As Ashley’s case shows, these exceptions are largely theoretical. Even if a victim files a police report, there appears to be no clear process for granting an exception. (The state Attorney General’s office did not

return TIME's repeated requests to clarify the process for granting exceptions; the Mississippi Board of Medical Licensure and the Mississippi State Medical Association did not reply to TIME's requests for explanation.) And, of course, there are no abortion providers left in the state. In January, the New York *Times* reported that since Mississippi's abortion law went into effect, only two exceptions had been made. Even if the process for obtaining one were clear, it wouldn't have helped Ashley. Regina didn't know that Mississippi's abortion ban had an exception for rape.

Even before *Dobbs*, it was perilous to become a mother in rural Mississippi. More than half the counties in the state can be classified as maternity-care deserts, according to a 2023 report from the March of Dimes, meaning there are no birthing facilities or obstetric providers. More than 24% of women in Mississippi have no birthing hospital within a 30-minute drive, compared to the national average of roughly 10%. According to Edney, there are just nine ob-gyns serving a region larger than the state of Delaware. Every time another ob-gyn retires, Balthrop gets an influx of new patients. "These patients are having to drive further to get the same care, then they're having to wait longer," Balthrop says.

Read More: *The Future of Abortion Access After* Roe v. Wade.

Those backups can have cascading effects. Balthrop recalls one woman who had to wait four weeks to get an appointment. "That's unacceptable, because you don't know if she's high risk or not until she sees you," the doctor says says. Her patient "didn't know she was pregnant. Now the time has lapsed so much that she can't drive anyplace to terminate even if she chose to."

Early data suggests the *Dobbs* decision will make this problem worse. Younger doctors and medical students say they don't want to move to states with abortion restrictions. When Emory University researcher Ariana Traub surveyed almost 500 third- and fourth-year medical students in 2022, close to 80% said that

abortion laws influenced where they planned to apply to residency. Nearly 60% said they were unlikely to apply to any residency programs in states with abortion restrictions. Traub had assumed that abortion would be most important to students studying obstetrics, but was surprised to find that three-quarters of students across all medical specialties said that *Dobbs* was affecting their residency decisions.

“People often forget that doctors are people and patients too,” Traub says. “And residency is often the time when people are in their mid-30s and thinking of starting a family.” Traub found that medical students weren’t just reluctant to practice in states with abortion bans. They didn’t want to become pregnant there, either.

And so *Dobbs* has compounded America’s maternal-health crisis: more women are delivering more babies, in areas where there are already not enough doctors to care for them, while abortion bans are making it more difficult to recruit qualified providers to the regions that need them most. “People always ask me: ‘Why do you choose to stay there?’” says Balthrop, who has worked in the Delta for more than 20 years. “I feel like I have no choice at this point.”

The weeks went on, and Ashley entered her second trimester. She wore bigger clothes to hide her bump, until she was so big that

Regina took her out of school. They told everyone Ashley needed surgery for a bad ulcer. “We’ve been keeping it quiet, because people judge wrong when they don’t know what’s going on,” Regina says. She’s been trying to keep Ashley away from “nosy people.” For months, Ashley spent most of the day alone, finishing up sixth grade on her laptop. The family still has no plans to tell anybody about the pregnancy. “It’s going to be a little private matter here,” Regina says.

Ashley has ADHD and trouble focusing, and has an Individualized Education Program at school. She had never talked much, but after the rape she went from shy to almost mute. Regina thinks she may have been too traumatized to speak. At first, Regina couldn’t even get Ashley to tell her about the rape at all.

In an interview in a side bedroom, while Ashley watched TV with Peanut in another room, Regina recounted the details of her daughter’s sexual assault, as she understands them. It was a weekend in the fall, shortly after lunchtime, and Ashley, then 12, had been outside their home making TikToks while her uncle and sibling were inside. A man came down the street and into the front yard, grabbed Ashley, and covered her mouth, Regina says. He pulled her around to the side of the house and raped her. Ashley told Regina that her assailant was an adult, and that she didn’t know him. Nobody else witnessed the assault.

Shortly after finding out Ashley was pregnant, Regina filed a complaint with the Clarksdale Police Department. The department’s assistant chief of police, Vincent Ramirez, confirmed to TIME that a police report had been filed in the matter, but refused to share the document because it involved a minor.

Regina says that another family member believed they had identified the rapist through social-media sleuthing. The family says they flagged the man they suspected to the police, but the investigation seemed to go nowhere. Ramirez declined to comment on an ongoing investigation, but an investigator in the department confirmed to TIME that an arrest has not yet been made. With their investigation still incomplete, police have not yet publicly confirmed that they believe Ashley's pregnancy resulted from sexual assault.

Regina felt the police weren't taking the case seriously. She says she was told that in order to move the investigation forward, the police needed DNA from the baby after its birth. Experts say this is not unusual. Although it is technically possible to obtain DNA from a fetus, police are often reluctant to initiate an invasive procedure on a pregnant victim, says Phillip Danielson, a professor of forensic genetics at the University of Denver. They typically test DNA only on fetal remains after an abortion, or after a baby is born, he says.

But almost three days after Peanut was born, the police still hadn't picked up the DNA sample; it was only after inquiries from TIME that officers finally arrived to collect it. Asked at the Clarksdale police station why it had taken so long after Peanut's birth for

crucial evidence to be collected, Ramirez shrugged. “It’s a pretty high priority, as a juvenile,” he says. “Sometimes they slip a little bit because we’ve got a lot going on, but then they come back to it.”

Ashley doesn’t say much when asked how it felt to learn she was pregnant. Her mouth twists into a shy grimace, and she looks away. “Not good,” she says after a long pause. “Not happy.”

Regina’s own feelings about abortion became more complicated as the pregnancy progressed. She got pregnant with her first daughter at 17, and was a mother at 18. “I was a teen,” says Regina, now 33. “But I wasn’t as young as her.”

Regina had considered abortion during one of her own pregnancies. But her grandmother admonished her, “Your mama didn’t abort you.” Now Regina felt caught between her family’s general disapproval of abortion and the realization that her 13-year-old daughter was pregnant as the result of a rape. “I wish she had just told me when it happened. We could have gotten Plan B or something,” Regina says, referring to the emergency contraceptive often known as the “morning-after pill.” “That would have been that.”

Balthrop often sees this kind of ambivalence. Clarksdale is in the heart of the Bible Belt, and many of her patients are Black women from religious families. Even if they want to terminate their pregnancies, Balthrop says, many of them ultimately decide not to go through with it. Since the *Dobbs* decision, however, Balthrop has seen an increase in "incomplete abortions," which is when the pregnancy has been terminated but the uterus hasn't been fully emptied. Medication abortions— abortions managed with pills, which are increasingly available online—are overwhelmingly safe, but occasionally can have minor complications when the pills are not taken exactly as directed. "They're having complications after —not serious, but they'll come in with significant bleeding, and then we still have to finish the process," Balthrop says, explaining that they sometimes have to evacuate dead fetal tissue.

According to Balthrop, Ashley didn't have complications during her pregnancy. But she didn't start speaking more until she felt the baby move, around her sixth month. "That's when it hit home," Balthrop says. "She'd complain about little aches and pains that she had never had before. That's when her mom would come in and say, 'She asked me this question,' and the three of us would sit and talk about it."

How did Ashley feel in anticipation of becoming a mother? "Nervous," is all she will say. Toward the end of the pregnancy, she was terrified of going into labor, Balthrop recalls. Most of her questions were about pushing, and delivery, and how painful it would be. She was focused on "the delivery process itself," Balthrop says. "Not, 'What am I going to do when I take this baby home?'"

The Clarksdale Woman's Clinic, where Balthrop practices, is across the street from the emergency room at Northwest Regional Medical Center, where Ashley first learned she was pregnant. The clinic is large and welcoming, with comfortable chairs and

paintings of flowers on the walls. The staff is kind and efficient, the space is clean, and it helps that the three ob-gyns on staff are Black, since most of the patients are Black women. The clinic's strong reputation attracts patients from an hour away in all directions. It is a lifeline in a vast region with few other maternity health options.

Even for healthy patients, it can be dangerous to be pregnant in such a rural area. "We have patients who walk to our clinic. They don't have transportation," says Casey Shoun, an administrative assistant at Clarksdale Woman's. Some can get Medicaid transportation, but it's notoriously unreliable. The trip can be hard even for local residents: the roads leading to the clinic don't have good sidewalks, and temperatures in the Delta regularly reach 100 degrees in the summer.

Shoun says the clinic gets patients who are six months pregnant by the time they have their first prenatal appointment. "We've had patients who go to the hospital, and they've already delivered," Shoun says. Balthrop recalls one woman who went into labor about seven weeks early, and had to drive 45 minutes to get to the hospital. She was too late. "By the time she got here, the baby had passed already," Balthrop says.

Clarksdale Woman's is equipped to handle routine appointments for a healthy pregnancy like Ashley's. But a pregnant woman with any complication at all—from deep-vein thrombosis to diabetes, preeclampsia to advanced maternal age—will have to make a three-hour round trip drive to Memphis to see the closest maternal-fetal-medicine specialist. The most vulnerable patients are often the ones who have to travel the farthest for pregnancy care.

Read More: *Inside Mississippi's Last Abortion Clinic.*

One morning in August, as the clinic filled, Balthrop allowed TIME to interview consenting patients in the waiting room and parking lot. One of them was Mikashia Hardiman, who is 18 years old and pregnant with her first child. Hardiman had just had her 20-week anatomy scan, and learned that she has a shortened cervix, which means her mother now has to drive her to Memphis to see a specialist.

Jessica Ray, 36, was 13 weeks pregnant with her third child. Three years ago, when she suddenly went into labor with her second child at 33 weeks, she drove herself 45 minutes to the hospital and delivered less than half an hour after she arrived. Ray knows the travel ordeals ahead of her: because she had preeclampsia with her first two pregnancies, she'll have to go see the specialist in Memphis each month. "You have to take off work and make sure somebody's getting your kids," Ray says.

Balthrop, who has three kids of her own, has long considered moving to a different region with a better education system. "I feel like I can't," she says. "I would be letting so many people down."

But the clinic is under serious financial strain. Between overhead, malpractice insurance, the increasing costs of goods and services, and decreasing insurance reimbursements, Balthrop and her colleagues can barely afford to keep Clarksdale Woman's open. They're considering selling the practice to a hospital 30 miles

away. If that happened, Balthrop says, babies would no longer be delivered in Clarksdale, a city of less than 15,000. Some of her patients would have to leave the Delta—possibly driving an hour or more—to get even the most basic maternity care.

For the patients who already struggle to make it to Clarksdale, that would spell disaster. “They just wouldn’t get care until they show up for delivery at the hospital,” says Shoun, the administrative assistant. “Imagine if we weren’t here. Where would they go?”

Ashley started feeling contractions on a Saturday afternoon when she was 39 weeks pregnant. She called Regina, who came home from work, and together they started timing them. They arrived at the hospital around 8 p.m. that night. An exam revealed Ashley was already six centimeters dilated. Her water broke soon after, and she got an epidural. She delivered Peanut within five hours. Ashley describes the birth in one word: “Painful.”

For Regina, the arrival of her first grandchild has not eased the pain of watching what her daughter has endured. “This situation hurts the most because it was an innocent child doing what children do, playing outside, and it was my child,” Regina says. “It still hurts, and is going to always hurt.”

Ashley doesn’t know anybody else who has a baby. She doesn’t want her three friends at school to find out that she has one now. Regina is working on an arrangement with the school so Ashley can start seventh grade from home until she’s ready to go back in person. Relatives will watch Peanut while Regina is at work. Is there anything about motherhood that Ashley is excited about? She twists her mouth, shrugs, and says nothing. Is there anything Ashley wants to say to other girls? “Be careful when you go outside,” she says. “And stay safe.”

There is only one moment when Ashley smiles a little, and it’s when she describes the nurses she met in the doctors’ office and delivery room. One of them, she remembers, was “nice” and “cool.” She has decided that when she grows up, she wants to be a nurse too. “To help people,” she says. For a second, she looks like any other soon-to-be seventh grader sharing her childhood dream. Then Peanut stirs in his car seat. Regina says he needs to be fed. Ashley’s face goes blank again. She is a mother now.

With reporting by Leslie Dickstein

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